# PREPARE TO WIN

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*How a World Champion Thinks, Leads and Builds Winning Teams*

HARRIE KWINTEN

**Prepare to Win – Doing Is the Best Way of Thinking**
**The Practical Method for Leadership, Performance Culture and Commercial Effectiveness**

Harrie Kwinten
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# FOREWORD

In elite sport, you cannot hide from the reality of the scoreboard.

In business, you can do so a little longer, but not endlessly.

Ultimately, practice reveals what has been built solidly and what was mainly well-packaged.

For me, that insight is not theory. I felt it on the field and later saw it again in boardrooms, in commercial teams and at organisations that wanted to grow.

Precisely because of that synergy, I felt that these two worlds belong together.

In both worlds, I saw the same pattern recur: people like to win but underestimate what structural winning demands of them.

They want results, but not always the discipline that precedes them. They want growth, but find it harder to truly adjust their behaviour. They want sharpness, but sometimes avoid the honesty that is needed for it.

These are important reasons why I wanted to write this book.

There is also a much more personal reason why I wrote this book.

When my sister Marella was on her deathbed, I made a promise. A promise to her, but perhaps even more importantly, a promise to myself. I promised that I would stop keeping so much of what I had learned to myself and start sharing it with others.

Moments like that change your perspective. Suddenly, the things you keep postponing no longer seem so unimportant. You

realise that experience has little value if all you do is carry it around with you. At some point, you have to pass it on.

I have been fortunate to experience extraordinary highs and difficult lows—first in elite sport and later throughout my international business career. I have won, lost, made mistakes, worked with exceptional people, faced pressure, learned from failure, and repeatedly discovered that the moments everyone sees are rarely the ones that determine the outcome. What happens beforehand matters far more.

Marella's death made me ask myself a simple but uncomfortable question: if I genuinely believe some of these lessons can help other people, what exactly am I waiting for?

This book is part of the answer to that question.

In that sense, Prepare to Win is more than a management book to me. It is also the fulfilment of a promise.

This book is written for leaders, entrepreneurs, commercial professionals, and teams who feel there is more potential to unlock and want to do more, rather than endlessly think about doing.

For leaders who provide direction under pressure. For teams that understand that trust is not soft, but functional. For commercial professionals who understand that winning does not start with persuading, but with understanding.

If, after reading this book, you hesitate about what to do, do not hesitate too long. Do it!

**Harrie Kwinten, 2026**

# INTRODUCTION

There are moments when an organisation shows exactly who it really is.

Not during an offsite day. Not in the strategy presentation. Not in the annual plan.

But at the moment when the pressure increases.

When an important customer threatens to drop out, when results are disappointing, when a team comes under pressure, when leadership is no longer theoretical, but must become practically tangible.

At such moments, the scenery falls away.

Then you see whether an organisation can only talk about peak performance, or whether that performance has truly been trained.

I do not want to romanticize elite sport, and I do not want to make business seem overly hard or cold. But I do want to draw attention to what has come under pressure in many organisations: discipline, rhythm, preparation, honesty, responsibility and the realization that sustainable performance never emerges by accident.

Too many organisations want to win without truly training.

They want growth without behavioural change. They want more commercial strength without learning to look sharper. They want a better culture without speaking up to each other clearly. They want development, but preferably without discomfort.

That does not work.

Anyone who wants to play at a higher level must accept that a higher level asks something extra: more sharpness, more honesty, more rhythm and more courage. Not occasionally, but applied structurally.

This book is not a collection of theories about motivation or leadership.

It is a plea for trainable behaviour and especially coachable performances. For taking behaviour more seriously. For coaching that takes place in practice.

Winning starts with preparation; for me, it means not only results achieved.

It means achieving results in a sustainable way that strengthens people and boosts organisational performance.

Too often, results are just temporary because the underlying basis is weak. Then revenue will grow, but energy will decline.

Ambition will rise, but collaboration will be poor. Goals will be achieved, but people lose each other.

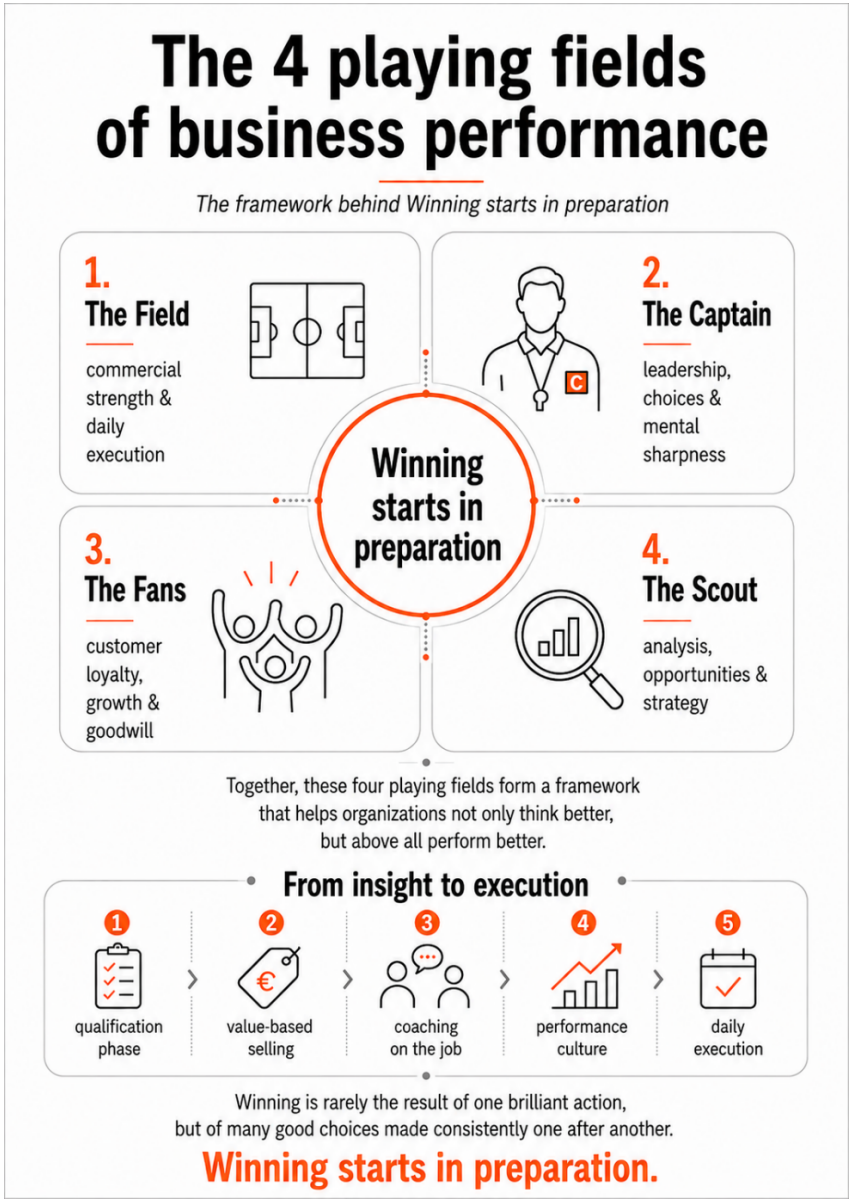
That is not real gain.

The professional I place at the centre of this book is someone I see too little of in many organisations and would like to see more often everywhere: someone who takes his profession seriously, does not spare himself in discipline, does not let the team drown in non-committal behaviour and understands that preparation is a form of respect.

For the customer. For the team. For the result. For yourself.

In this book, I take you through four playing fields of business performance:

- The Field, where commercial strength and daily execution matter;
- The Captain, for whom leadership, choices and mental sharpness are decisive;
- The Fans, where customer loyalty, growth and goodwill make the difference;
- The Scout, where analysis, opportunities and strategy come together.




Together, these four playing fields form a framework with which organisations cannot only think better, but especially perform better.

In addition, I address fifteen strategies in this book that prove their relevance again and again in practice.

Among others, the qualification phase (what the organisation and its decision structure really look like), which business challenges actually run within the company, value-based selling (what real added value my product or service delivers), coaching on the job (how you help employees in the field really get better), ... and more.

These strategies should not be applied as separate tricks but as part of a broader performance vision, because winning is rarely the result of a single brilliant action. Usually, it is the result of many good choices made consistently, one after another.This book is particularly suited to organisations that are not satisfied with mediocrity.

For people who understand that pressure is not an excuse, but part of the playing field. And for everyone who wants to build a culture in which ambition, discipline, sharpness and collaboration are not incidentally visible, but become daily tangible.

The question is not whether your organisation has talent, whether it trains like a champion, whether you have a strategy, or whether your team translates that strategy into behaviour, choices and results every day.

The question is not whether you want to win; the question is what you are willing to do to become structurally better.

Because in business, just as in elite sport, winning never starts on the day of the match.

**Winning starts in preparation.**

If this is the standard you want to move towards, then the coaching starts here.

PART

# I

# THE MINDSET OF PREPARE TO WIN

CHAPTER

# 01

# WHY ELITE SPORT AND BUSINESS ARE THE SAME ARENA

STATEMENT

*Anyone who truly understands elite sport knows that winning never starts with the scoreboard, but with the standard you demand of yourself every day.*

At first glance, elite sport and business seem like two different worlds. The sport is played on a field, in a stadium, or in an arena. The game of business is played in offices, boardrooms, customer conversations, and ever-changing markets.

Look closely, and you see that the laws of performance in both worlds are strikingly similar. In both worlds, it ultimately comes down to the same thing: being ready when it matters most.

Key aspects include: performing under pressure, staying focused when others drop off, and continuing to improve when success tempts you to become complacent.

As a former elite athlete, I have experienced first-hand what it takes to perform at a high level.

Not once, but time and time again.

This requires more than talent. Talent helps, but it is never enough.

Winning consistently requires preparation, discipline, adaptability, mental sharpness, and a willingness to take an honest look at what needs improvement.

This is where I clearly see the parallel with business.

Organisations do not win because they have the most compelling story. They win because they are better prepared to turn ambition into execution and execution into results.

Throughout my career, I have come to know both worlds from the inside.

Sports shaped me in discipline, rhythm, teamwork, and resilience under pressure.

Business taught me how complex human dynamics, commercial decision-making, and organisational behaviour can be.

In sports, you see immediately what works and what does not work.

In business, poor preparation can sometimes remain hidden for a while behind polished language, presentations, or processes.

Ultimately, reality catches up with everyone. Results are always more honest than intentions.

What has always stayed with me from my time in sport is that no one can perform under the radar there.

Your level is visible. Your preparation is visible. Your focus is visible. Your recovery is visible.

In business, this is often less clear-cut. You can sometimes get by for quite some time on reputation, position, communication skills, or simply by appearing busy.

But in every company, sooner or later, the moment arrives when it truly matters.

A key client, a difficult decision, a team that gets stuck, a disappointing quarter. That is when you find out whether the foundations are strong enough.

I have often seen organisations being surprised by declining performance, even though the warning signs had been visible for months.

Appointments that were prepared with less rigour. Meetings in which no one addressed the real tension. Commercial processes in which there was too much telling and too little discovery. Leaders who felt a strong sense of responsibility, but brought too little rhythm.

The problem is that these patterns seem insignificant when they occur in isolation. But taken together, they ultimately determine the outcome.

This is exactly why I believe so strongly in the Business Athlete mindset—or, more precisely, in the principle that people and organisations should take performance seriously as something that can be deliberately trained.

Not: how do I sound, but: how do I perform? Not: how do I come across, but: am I prepared? Not: how busy am I, but: what do I actually deliver? These are simple questions, but they are relentlessly effective.

**With this book, Prepare to Win, I bring the principles of elite sport into business. Not as a nice metaphor, but as a practical way of working.**

In many organisations, knowledge is abundant.

There are enough plans, analyses, dashboards and meetings.

Knowledge by itself does not deliver results.

Results emerge when people in the workplace actually learn, act, adjust and take responsibility.

Therefore, I strongly believe in on-the-job coaching and learning by doing. Not only do we talk about performance, but we also improve performance through training, coaching, and action.

We live in a time when organisations have access to more knowledge than ever before, but knowing more does not automatically lead to better behaviour.

There is no shortage of information. No shortage of models. No shortage of strategy presentations, leadership programs, or dashboards filled with KPIs.

Yet in many organisations there is a lack of sharpness, ownership, commercial discipline and real execution power.

You see this at every level. Teams work hard, but not always effectively.

Leaders manage on ambition, but not consistently on behaviour.

Professionals have knowledge, but do not translate that sufficiently into concrete performance. Meetings are full of intention, but short on decision-making power.

There is a great deal of talk about change, but far less training and coaching in the skills that actually make change possible.

**That is exactly where the thinking behind this book comes into play.**

The professional at the heart of this book is not necessarily the fastest, loudest, or most visible person in the organisation.

It is the professional who understands that performance is a craft, that winning is no coincidence, that discipline is more rewarding than procrastination, that preparation is a sign of respect for your opponent, that collaboration is a skill rather than something to be taken for granted. And that pressure is not a disruption, but part of the playing field.

**This book is therefore not written for people looking for a few isolated tips. It is written for people who want to build a different level of performance.**

**For leaders who feel their team has more potential than it is currently realizing.**

**For commercial professionals who not only want to win more deals, but want to learn to look, listen, move and persuade better.**

For organisations that understand that culture is not decoration, but a performance engine.

The essence of this book is simple: organisations can learn a great deal from elite sport precisely because it is so ruthlessly honest. There is no hiding from it. The competition reveals whether your preparation was good enough.

The score shows whether your plan worked. The moments of pressure reveal whether your team truly is a team.

**Business is no different. The only difference is that the signals are less clear-cut, the excuses more socially acceptable, and the evasions often more cleverly disguised.**

This is one of the reasons why this book is so needed.

Not to romanticize business as an elite sport. Nor to push every organisation into a permanent state of competition.

But to bring back a way of thinking and working that many organisations have lost along the way: sharpness, rhythm, accountability, training, coaching, discipline, and the courage to turn honest feedback into better behaviour.

That is what Prepare to Win is all about.

Most people associate elite sport with winning. I associate elite sport first with preparation.

That sounds perhaps less spectacular, but it is precisely there where the difference is made.

That difference is not made on the stage, in the review afterwards, or in the applause.

The real difference is made in the hours and days before it becomes visible.

In discipline: in repetition, in correcting, in focusing, in recovering, in starting again when something is not yet good enough.

That is also precisely why elite sport and business at their core play in the same arena.

Many people see elite sport and business as two completely different worlds.

In elite sport, it is primarily about physical performance, competition, discipline, and winning.

In business, it is about revenue, customers, strategy, innovation, and growth.

Yet that distinction is more superficial than it seems.

Under the surface, the same laws apply.

Anyone who wants to win must continuously improve. Anyone who wants to perform under pressure must be prepared. Anyone who wants sustainable success must learn to deal with setbacks, competition, and change.

In elite sport, this is very visible.

You cannot bluff the scoreboard. You cannot hide whether you are fit, sharp, or ready for the game. In business, this is sometimes more subtle.

There, you can conceal poor preparation for longer behind words, presentations, or impressive plans.

But ultimately, the market always catches up with you.

Customers feel it when you are not sharp. Teams feel it when leaders hesitate.

Results show whether an organisation is in control or merely looks busy.

High-level performance requires the same combination of factors in both worlds: clear goals, consistent preparation, mental resilience, strong collaboration, and the ability to learn.

That is precisely why elite sport is such a powerful mirror for organisations. In sport, you see magnified what also plays out in business: focus beats fragmentation, rhythm beats impulsiveness, and discipline beats randomness.

Most organisations do not lose because they lack talent.

They lose because talent is not systematically converted into behaviour.

Because preparation is inconsistent, feedback comes too late; when busyness is mistaken for performance, leaders react too much to incidents and focus too little on driving continuous improvement.

I have seen countless situations in business where the intentions were good, but the execution fell short.

Teams that talk about customer focus but enter conversations insufficiently prepared.

Leaders who set ambitious targets but remain unclear about the behaviour required to achieve them. Organisations that invest in training without ensuring that what has been learned is actually applied in the workplace.

The result is predictable: plenty of activity, limited progress.

A scene I often picture is that of a team that, after a disappointing quarter, immediately starts looking for new actions: more

leads, even more campaigns, even more customer visits, even more internal alignment.

As if more activity automatically means better results. In elite sport, a good coach would do something different first: look back, slow down, analyse. Where did things really go wrong? Was it the timing, the preparation, the discipline, the collaboration? That kind of reflection is something I still see too little of in organisations. People are quicker to jump into action than to step back and analyse.

In elite sport, a teammate, as well as a coach, would confront you. A competition would ruthlessly expose that the level is simply not good enough yet.

In business, those signals are less clear-cut: directness is often softened by politeness, busyness, or the desire to preserve harmony.

But harmony without performance is rarely sustainable.

Ultimately, even greater tension arises when results fail to materialize, and no one honestly addresses why.

The professional I place at the centre of this book understands this. Someone who realizes that business success is no coincidence, but the result of daily training.

Not only train in the traditional sense of the word, but also in thinking, decision-making, collaboration, communication, selling, and recovery.

That professional does not only ask, "What needs to be done today?" They also ask: What do we need to train to be better tomorrow than we are today?

This is the essence of this book: not working harder, but preparing smarter. Not reacting when it is already too late, but building systematically. Not hoping for results, but creating the behaviours that make results more likely.

PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

Think of a commercial team that goes out into the market full of energy every week, but consistently spends too little time on preparation.

There are plenty of customer meetings, plenty of activity, plenty of internal discussions. Yet the results continue to fall short.

Why? Because busyness is seen as evidence of performance. While the real cause often lies elsewhere: insufficient research, too little insight into the decision-making process, poor follow-up, or unclear roles and responsibilities.

In elite sport, no one would say: "We worked hard enough and were active enough, so it was a good game." What matters there is the quality of execution. In business, we should set the bar just as high.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

1. Where in our organisation do we mistake busyness for performance?
2. Which talents remain underutilized because we do not spend enough time developing the right behaviours?
3. What are we good at talking about, but not yet good enough at putting into practice?

An important difference between good intentions and real performance is that intentions often remain verbal, whereas performance is always visible in behaviour. In organisations, you regularly hear that people want to become more customer-focused, sharper, or more entrepreneurial. But the question is never whether people want that. The question is whether daily routines also enforce, support and correct that behaviour.

In elite sport, no one improves simply by saying they want to get better. A training schedule is put in place, performance is

measured, progress is reviewed, adjustments are made, and the process is repeated. That very simplicity is missing in many organisations. They have ambition, but no training rhythm. They have goals, but no clear standards of behaviour. They have meetings, but too little correction of how things are actually executed.

That is why the comparison with elite sport is so valuable. Not because business should become a competition stripped of humanity, but because elite sport shows that high performance is only sustainable when people know what is expected of them and are willing to keep developing themselves accordingly.

What is often underestimated in this context is the value of repetition. In sport, repetition is not seen as a lack of inspiration, but as the path to reliability. In business, people are often quicker to look for something new, while the answer frequently lies in executing what they already know more effectively. An organisation that matures in this respect creates calm rather than noise.

It also requires a different language. Less talk about busyness, more about progress. Less about good intentions, more about observable behaviour. Less about talent, more about the ability to develop through training. That language makes performance concrete and helps leaders not only to inspire, but also to correct where necessary.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

Imagine an organisation that presents an ambitious growth plan. The strategy works on paper, the market seems attractive, and the people are capable. Nevertheless, the result lags. Not because the plan is bad, but because daily execution has not been trained. Customer conversations are prepared inconsistently, follow-up depends entirely on personal discipline, and feedback comes only when a quarter disappoints. The problem, then, lies not in ambition but in performance behaviour.

An elite sports coach would not start with a new challenge in a situation like this. They would look at the training. What happens every week? Which standards are repeated? Where are correc-

tions made? Who takes ownership when things get difficult? Translating those questions into a business context creates a much more honest picture of the organisation's true performance capacity.

The lesson is clear: anyone who wants to improve consistently must look not only at strategy, but also at how people prepare, execute, evaluate, and recover every day. That is where elite sport and business truly come together.

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CHAPTER

# 02

# WINNING STARTS BEFORE THE MATCH

STATEMENT

> *Preparation is the most underestimated form of respect: for the customer, the team, the result, and yourself.*

Most games are lost before they even begin.

Not because the talent is lacking. Not because the opponent is unbeatable. But because the preparation was not good enough.

Because details were overlooked, assumptions were not tested, and the focus was too broad.

Because people wanted to perform but were not truly ready.

Many organisations want to win, but relatively few actually train and are coached to win.

They talk about growth, ambition, and performance, but pay too little attention to preparation.

Yet it is precisely in the preparation that the difference is made. Not when the pressure is at its highest, but in the phase leading up to it. In the way people prepare themselves, think through scenarios, align roles, and manage expectations.

An athlete knows that preparation is not merely a prerequisite, but lies at the very heart of performance.

The warm-up, nutrition, analysis of the opponent, recovery, training rhythm, mental sharpness: everything contributes to being ready when it matters most.

It's no different in business. A sales conversation, a board meeting, a negotiation, or a strategic decision is rarely won through pure improvisation. It is won through preparation.

In business, preparation means knowing the customer's real need. Understanding the interests behind the words. Knowing who has influence and who makes the decision. Thinking through different scenarios. Being able to anticipate potential objections. Knowing the difference between activity and progress.

The biggest problem is that many teams confuse preparation with information.

Teams have plenty of slides, plenty of data, plenty of notes, but too little clarity and focus.

Preparation is not about the amount of material you bring with you. Preparation is about how well you understand a situation, whether you have a plan, and whether you are ready to make good decisions under pressure.

I have seen professionals enter a conversation with an overloaded presentation, yet unable to answer the most basic question: what really matters to this customer?

I have seen management teams prepare a strategy extensively on paper, but fail to think sufficiently about the behavioural changes that strategy will require from people tomorrow. That, too, is a failure of preparation. Not in terms of content, but in practical terms.

Winning does not begin with performance in the moment itself. Winning starts much earlier.

It lies in discipline, rhythm, self-reflection, honest analysis, and the courage to admit where you are not yet ready.

That is what makes preparation so powerful.

I learned just how unforgiving that principle can be during my own sporting career. And perhaps the lesson was so powerful because, at the time, we had every reason to believe we were ready. We were not an inexperienced team trying to find our way. We were World Champions.

### The Missing Two Per Cent

We were fit. We were experienced. We were confident. And yet, when it mattered, we discovered that we had not prepared for everything.

Two years after becoming World Champions, we arrived at the 1992 Olympic Games in Barcelona with every reason to believe in ourselves.

We were extremely fit. We were fully committed. We had already proved that we could perform at the highest level.

And perhaps that was exactly where the danger began.

The Olympic Village, located beside Barcelona's beautiful old harbour, was everything I had imagined—and more. Then came the Opening Ceremony.

It was breathtaking. Well... almost.

Before we could enter the stadium for the opening ceremony, we spent nearly two and a half hours slowly shuffling forward in the scorching Spanish heat. Barcelona rarely disappoints when it comes to sunshine, and the opening day was no exception. Eventually, the wait was over. Let the Games begin.

How do you describe the feeling of walking into an Olympic stadium for the opening ceremony alongside more than 250 fellow Dutch athletes, with billions of people watching around the world?

It is overwhelming. You feel emotional. You feel incredibly proud.

But underneath all those emotions, one thought dominates everything else: **You didn't come here simply to participate. You came to win Olympic gold.**

We genuinely believed we were capable of winning Olympic gold.

But we didn't. And looking back, I believe our previous success may have played a part.

Becoming World Champions gave us confidence. But confidence can quietly become expectation.

Without ever saying it aloud, perhaps part of us thought:

*We're the World Champions. Surely we'll win Olympic gold too.*

**Elite sport doesn't work that way.**

Past success guarantees absolutely nothing.

Every training session starts at zero.

Every match starts at zero.

**Yesterday's medals do not score today's goals.**

Maybe we didn't compete at 100 per cent.

Maybe we competed at 98 per cent.

To most people, that sounds insignificant.

At Olympic level, those missing two per cent can be the difference between standing on top of the podium and watching somebody else receive the medal you came to win.

Barcelona taught me that talent is not enough. Fitness is not enough. Commitment is not enough. Even having been successful before is not enough.

In fact, previous success can sometimes become part of the problem. It can quietly convince you that what worked yesterday will be enough tomorrow.

Elite performance demands something different. It requires you to keep asking:

What are we missing?

What haven't we prepared for?

Where are we relying on confidence when we should be relying on preparation?

That lesson has stayed with me throughout my business career.

I have seen organisations arrive at the equivalent of their own Olympic Games believing they were ready. The presentation looked excellent. The team knew the customer. The proposition was strong. Everyone was confident.

But they hadn't rehearsed the difficult questions.

They hadn't identified the real decision-maker.

They hadn't considered what the competitor might do.

They hadn't agreed what would happen if the meeting suddenly moved in a different direction.

They had prepared 98 per cent.

And sometimes the missing two per cent becomes 100 per cent of the reason you lose.

That is what Barcelona taught me.

The missing two per cent rarely looks dramatic before the match. Under pressure, it can become the entire match.

Many years later, I returned to Barcelona and first visited the Olympic Village again.

Almost everything had changed. The athletes' accommodation had become a modern apartment complex. The enormous dining hall where thousands of Olympians had once shared their meals had been transformed into a multi-storey car park.

Then I walked back into the Olympic Stadium.

And something happened that I hadn't expected.

I felt a knot in my stomach.

For a few moments, my entire sporting life seemed to replay itself.

The dreams.

The sacrifices.

The victories.

The disappointments.

And I remembered what it had felt like to believe we were almost invincible.

That feeling eventually disappears. The lesson doesn't.

Success is never something you own.

It is something you have to earn again, every single day.

Preparation is not only a technical process; it is also a mental choice.

By preparing, you are saying: we take the competition seriously before it even begins.

The best professionals are often recognized not only by how they perform, but by how they prepare.

They do not simply make a strong entrance; they have already thought through the route, the objective, the dynamics, and the possible resistance. That creates calm. And that calm improves quality and strengthens confidence.

PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

For every important conversation, a team should have clarity on at least five things:

1. What is really at stake in this conversation?
2. What interests are at play beneath the surface?
3. Who influences the outcome, both formally and informally?
4. What resistance or doubts can we expect?
5. What behaviour on our part will increase the chances of success?

Preparation is also a way to reduce tension. If you are poorly prepared, you have to improvise under pressure. If you are well prepared, you can make choices under pressure. That is a significant difference. Improvisation can sometimes appear creative, but it becomes dangerous when it is used as an excuse for a lack of structure.

In commercial processes, for example, you see this in teams that only after a customer meeting discover which questions they should have asked beforehand. Or in leaders who only start thinking about roles, communication, and decision-making once a crisis has already begun. By then, you are effectively too late. Good preparation does not eliminate all uncertainty, but it ensures that uncertainty does not immediately lead to chaos.

The best preparation is concrete. Not simply: we need to be sharp. But: which three questions do we need to ask? Which decision do we want to move closer to? Who takes which role? What do we do if the customer shows resistance? What is the minimum outcome we want to achieve? Questions like these make preparation practical and force a team to think maturely in advance.

Good preparation always includes a form of mental rehearsal. What could happen? Where could the conversation shift? Which question could catch us by surprise? What emotions might the

other person be experiencing? By thinking through scenarios in advance, you improve not only your clarity of thought, but also your composure.

And that composure makes the difference. A well-prepared professional does not need to constantly prove themselves. They can listen, slow down, and connect. That creates greater influence. Preparation is therefore not an administrative step, but a way to raise quality, confidence, and timing to a higher level.

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### Preparing for the room, not just the presentation

I learned that the final percentage points of preparation matter just as much in business as they do in elite sport. One boardroom presentation taught me that being prepared is not simply about knowing your slides. It is about being prepared for the room.

When I worked for a large publicly listed IT company, I had to present my plans and figures to the Executive Board once a month.

The board consisted of five sharp, experienced and highly intelligent men. They also had a reputation for putting presenters under pressure and, occasionally, making them feel small in the room.

I knew that before I walked in.

So I prepared accordingly.

The rule was simple: your PowerPoint deck and figures had to be submitted the afternoon before the meeting so the board could review them in advance.

Most presenters build a clear storyline. Slide one leads to slide two, slide two to slide three, and eventually to the conclusions and recommendations at the end.

That structure creates confidence.

But it can also create dependency.

Because once the board has seen the entire deck, they are no longer obliged to follow your sequence.

You may be explaining slide two when someone suddenly asks a question about slide six.

And in that moment, your carefully prepared storyline disappears.

That is where many presenters lose control.

They know the presentation.

But they do not yet own the content.

When it happened to me, I was ready.

I was still on slide two when a board member challenged me with a question about something that appeared several slides later.

I answered immediately. Calmly. Confidently. And with a smile.

I did not need to say, "We'll come to that later." I did not need to recover my place.

I knew the material well enough to move the discussion wherever it needed to go.

After that, I noticed a change in the room. They could still challenge me, and they did, but I was no longer dependent on the sequence of my slides.

Because they realised something important.

I was not presenting slides. I owned the story.

That experience reinforced a lesson I had already learned in elite sport:

You do not prepare only for your own performance. You prepare for the environment in which that performance has to succeed.

In a boardroom, that means knowing more than your slides.

Who is in the room?

What matters to each person?

Who has influence?

Which questions are likely to come?

Where might resistance appear?

What does each slide actually mean to them?

What do you want them to think, feel, or decide by the end?

A presentation can be perfectly prepared and still be poorly prepared for the audience.

That is why preparation must go beyond the deck.

**Prepare for the room.**



Preparation is therefore not extra work. It is the foundation of professional performance. It reduces the role of chance and increases the likelihood of quality when the pressure is on.

You cannot prepare for everything. But the better you prepare, the less you have to hope that everything goes your way.

Winning starts before the match.

CHAPTER

# 03

# PERFORMANCE CULTURE IS NO COINCIDENCE

STATEMENT

*Culture is more important than strategy.*

Every organisation has a culture. But not every organisation has a performance culture.

That difference is crucial.

Culture is what people do when no one is watching. It consists of the standards that are not written on posters, but become visible through behaviour.

It is how teams deal with commitments, responsibility, pressure, feedback, and ownership.

A performance culture does not emerge by itself. Nor is it created by an inspiring kick-off or a powerful slogan.

It is built through small, daily actions.

In the way someone prepares for a meeting. In how feedback is given. In how consistent leaders are. In how teams respond to mistakes. In how high the standard truly is.

In elite sport, that culture is immediately tangible. You can feel it in the discipline of training, the sharpness of the analysis, and the natural way in which people hold one another accountable.

In business, this is often less explicit.

That creates room for mediocrity.

Being late suddenly becomes acceptable. Being only half-prepared is no longer seen as a problem. A lack of follow-up becomes normalized.

The result is predictable: less sharpness, less trust, and fewer results.

A performance culture requires three things:

1. Clear standards. People need to know what good looks like.
2. Leaders who lead by example. What leaders tolerate becomes culture.
3. Repetition. Culture does not change through a single intervention, but through rhythm.

Many organisations underestimate that last point.

They want cultural change, but approach it too sporadically.

There may be an off-site meeting, an inspirational session, or the presentation of a new set of values, but afterwards daily practice simply returns to the way it was before.

Real cultural change only happens when the desired behaviour consistently becomes part of preparation, meetings, feedback, coaching, performance reviews, decision-making, and course correction.

Culture is also visible in what is not discussed. Are missed opportunities evaluated honestly? Are poor meetings called out? Can doubts about leadership be discussed openly? Is mediocrity corrected?

Or does everyone continue to move politely around one another without addressing the real issues? In those silences, culture is often shaped more powerfully than through official statements.

Organisations that want to consistently improve their performance need to stop treating culture as an abstract concept.

Culture is behaviour. Behaviour can be trained and coached.

And what can be trained and coached can therefore be influenced. That makes performance culture not a mystery, but a management responsibility.

That is precisely why on-the-job coaching is so relevant to cultural change.

Culture does not change through intention, but through behaviour that is observed, reflected upon, and sharpened in practice.

When employees receive immediate feedback, learn more quickly from their own context, and visibly develop in preparation, communication, and ownership, the standard within a team begins to shift.

What was once the exception gradually becomes the standard.

The impact is not only felt internally.

A stronger performance culture also translates into higher productivity, better collaboration, less frustration, greater trust, higher employee satisfaction, and ultimately stronger commercial results.

Organisations that invest in human capital therefore strengthen not only their culture, but also their reputation as an employer and their ability to compete effectively in the market.

Anyone who treats culture merely as a soft factor misses the point.

**A performance culture is not a feel-good initiative, but an operational system.**

It determines how quickly people learn, how consistently commitments are kept, how honestly teams are willing to reflect, and how reliably an organisation continues to perform under pressure.

Culture belongs at the heart of business, not at the margins.

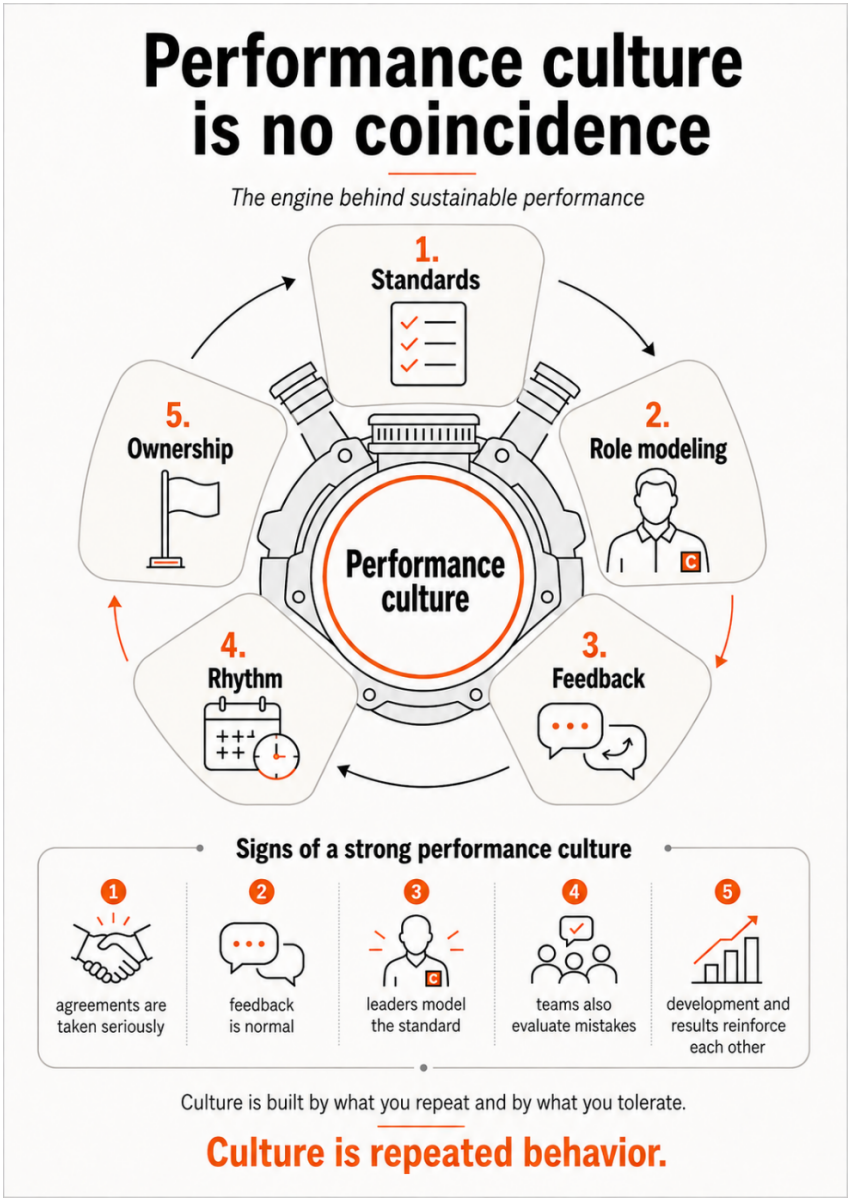
In organisations where coaching on the job is structurally embedded, culture often becomes tangible much faster.

Not because people suddenly adopt different values, but because the desired behaviour is identified, practiced, and repeated more consistently.

Preparation becomes more visible. Feedback becomes more normal. Ownership becomes less optional.

Daily repetition ensures that culture no longer remains an abstract concept, but becomes a practical reality.

For employees, that difference is significant as well. In a strong performance culture, people have a clearer understanding of what is expected of them, receive useful feedback more quickly, and experience greater direction in their development.



This reduces uncertainty, builds self-confidence, and decreases the frustration that arises when expectations remain implicit. What feels like sharpness to the organisation often feels like clarity and room for growth to the professional.

For leaders, this means that cultural change does not begin with communication, but with rhythm.

Which behaviours are made visible every week? What is being coached? Which standards repeatedly appear in meetings, customer preparation, decision-making, and follow-up? Those who take these rhythms seriously build culture. Those who do not leave culture to chance.

### What a Strong Performance Culture Looks Like

A strong performance culture can often be recognized by five clear signs:

1. Commitments are taken seriously and are not constantly reopened for negotiation.
2. Feedback is not reserved for formal moments, but is part of everyday work.
3. Leaders demonstrate through their own behaviour that preparation, discipline, and responsibility are the standard.
4. Teams evaluate not only successes, but also mistakes, without falling into a blame game.
5. People understand that development and results are not opposing forces, but reinforce one another.

**Signs of a weak performance culture:**

1. People find it easier to talk about ambition than about behaviour.
2. There is plenty of activity, but too little discipline and focus in follow-up.
3. Feedback is seen as uncomfortable and is therefore postponed.

4 Leaders express high expectations, but tolerate performance that falls below those expectations.

5 Successes are celebrated, but mistakes are rarely properly analysed.

A performance culture is often confused with toughness. That is a misconception. A healthy performance culture is not one in which people are under constant pressure, but one in which clarity, responsibility, and development are normal. That is precisely what creates greater safety. People know where they stand, what they can rely on, and where they have room to grow.

The weakest culture is often not the one in which mistakes are made, but the one in which mistakes are not discussed. When that happens, learning stops. People protect themselves, teams avoid honest conversations, and leaders develop an overly positive view of reality. A performance culture breaks that pattern by treating feedback not as an attack but as a way to maintain the standard.

Anyone who wants to improve culture should therefore not start with a poster on the wall, but with the question of which behaviours need to become visible every week. Prepare properly. A commitment is a commitment. Briefly evaluate after a conversation. Understand successes. Analyse mistakes. Small routines, repeated consistently, eventually change the standard.

In a performance culture, standards are not only stated, but also upheld. That may sound strict, but it is actually fair. When commitments can constantly be shifted, ambiguity becomes the norm. When preparation is optional, mediocrity gradually becomes acceptable. Culture is built by what you repeat and by what you tolerate.

Leadership plays a decisive role in this. Leaders do not have to be perfect, but they do have to be consistent. What they let slide becomes permission for others. What they visibly value becomes attractive. And what they demonstrate through their own behaviour carries more weight than any presentation about values or behaviour.

PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

An organisation says that keeping commitments is important. Yet meetings regularly start late, actions are postponed, and evaluations remain superficial. No one wants to make an issue of it, so everyone accepts it. Over time, it is not the stated value that becomes the culture, but the behaviour that is tolerated. That is how mediocrity gradually becomes the norm.

Change does not begin with grand words, but with small consequences. Meetings start on time. Actions are assigned an owner and a deadline. After important moments, there is a brief evaluation. Leaders ask not only what happened, but also what behaviour led to it. In this way, the standard shifts step by step.

A performance culture emerges when an organisation takes its own standards seriously enough to uphold them every day. Not being tough for the sake of being tough, but being clear because clarity helps people perform better.

CHAPTER

# 04

# CULTURE AS THE INVISIBLE PLAYING FIELD

STATEMENT

> *Culture is not what an organisation says it considers important, but what it continues to repeat under pressure.*

Every organisation has a culture.

But not every organisation understands how powerfully that culture shapes performance every single day.

Culture is the invisible playing field on which everything happens.

It determines how people deal with pressure, mistakes, success, customers, colleagues, leadership, and responsibility. It determines what is considered normal. What is rewarded, what is avoided, what is discussed, and above all: what remains unspoken.

In many organisations, culture only becomes a topic of conversation when something goes wrong. When people disengage, when collaboration becomes difficult, when commercial results fall short, when talent leaves, and certainly when teams become cynical. Or when leaders sense that energy is draining from the organisation.

But culture does not only exist when things go wrong. Culture is always there.

Culture is at work every day. In every meeting, every customer conversation, every preparation, every response to feedback, and every commitment, whether kept or broken.

That is what makes culture so decisive. Not because it is a soft factor, but because it continuously shapes behaviour.

### Culture Is the Behaviour That Is Allowed

One of the most underestimated truths about culture is this: culture is shaped not only by what leaders say but, above all, by what they allow.

When a commitment can be shifted without consequence, the team learns that commitments are relative.

When poor preparation is not addressed, the team learns that preparation is optional.

When feedback is postponed, the team learns that comfort is more important than growth.

When mediocrity is tolerated, mediocrity gradually becomes the norm.

This rarely happens consciously.

Almost no one explicitly decides to build a mediocre culture.

Yet that is often exactly how it develops: through small concessions, repeated behaviour, and the avoidance of uncomfortable conversations.

In short: culture is created through repetition and defined by what a team accepts.

### The Visible Layer and the Underlying Current

Anyone who wants to understand culture needs to learn to look at two layers.

The visible layer is what can be seen.

It includes strategy, values, goals, KPIs, processes, job profiles, and presentations.

The underlying current is less visible.

It consists of the unwritten rules, patterns, tensions, fears, beliefs, and habits.

Many organisations try to change culture through the visible layer. They define new values, organize a session, create posters, launch a program, or communicate a new ambition.

That can be useful, but it is rarely enough.

The real culture lives in the underlying current.

That is where the real questions exist: am I allowed to say honestly what I see here? Is preparation genuinely valued? Is feedback safe or dangerous? Is ownership rewarded or does it mainly lead to extra workload? Are leaders willing to be corrected themselves? Are we more demanding about behaviour or more forgiving because intentions are good?

It is precisely in that underlying current that it is determined whether an organisation truly learns.

### The Five Cultural Layers of Performance

A performance culture can be examined in depth through five layers:

#### 1 The language of the organization

What do people talk about a lot? And what do they avoid talking about?

An organisation that mainly talks about busyness will reinforce busyness. An organisation that talks about behaviour, progress, and quality makes performance more concrete.

#### 2 The standard of behavior

What do we consider normal here?

Do you come prepared? Do you follow up? Do you hold others accountable? Do you reflect afterwards? Do you take responsibility? The standard is not what is written down, but what is visible every day.

### 3 The response to pressure

Every culture reveals itself most honestly under pressure.

When results disappoint, you see whether a team learns, blames, avoids, excuses, or accelerates.

### 4 The quality of feedback

Feedback is the bloodstream of a performance culture.

Where feedback stops, learning stops. Where feedback becomes normal, development accelerates.

### 5 The example set by leaders

Leaders are culture amplifiers.

Not because they determine everything, but because their behaviour carries disproportionate weight. What leaders let slide becomes permission for others. What leaders consistently demonstrate through their own behaviour becomes the norm more quickly.

**Culture Diagnosis: Where Is the Real Constraint?**

A culture problem is often disguised as a different problem.

A sales problem is sometimes not really a sales problem, but a culture problem.

For example, because people do not hold one another accountable for poor preparation.

A leadership problem is sometimes not really a leadership problem, but a culture problem.

For example, because indecisiveness has been socially accepted for years.

A collaboration problem is sometimes not really a collaboration problem, but a culture problem.

For example, because teams place their own interests above the collective result.

A performance problem is sometimes not really a performance problem, but a culture problem.

For example, because the organisation expresses high ambitions but tolerates low standards.

That is why cultural change does not begin with inspiration, but with diagnosis.

Not: what do we want to become?

But first: what are we unconsciously reinforcing today?

### The Culture Mirror

A practical culture mirror can consist of seven questions:

1. Which behaviours do we say are important, but fail to correct sufficiently?
2. Which commitments are too easily reopened for negotiation in our organization?
3. Where do we confuse harmony with mature collaboration?
4. Which feedback is given too late, too cautiously, or not at all?
5. Which leadership behaviours unintentionally reinforce the old culture?
6. Where are our standards clear, but our follow-through weak?
7. What needs to be visibly different in our behaviour within ninety days?

These questions take culture out of the abstract.

They reveal where the organisation is holding itself back.

### A Performance Culture Is Not About Toughness

At this deeper level, a performance culture is not about toughness, but about clear and effective workplace behaviour. People perform better when they know what good looks like, what standard applies, and how they can develop towards that standard.

A performance culture is not about being tougher on people.

It is about being more honest about behaviour.

It is not about judging people.

It is about helping people grow.

It is not about constantly increasing the pressure.

It is about making clear what good looks like, where the bar is set, and how someone can improve.

In a weak culture, feedback feels uncomfortable because it is experienced as criticism.

In a strong culture, feedback is normal because it is seen as a way of maintaining the standard.

That difference is enormous.

### From Values to Workplace Behaviour

Many organisations have values such as customer-focused, entrepreneurial, professional, reliable, innovative, or results-oriented.

But values change very little as long as they are not translated into workplace behaviour.

"Customer-focused" only becomes part of the culture when someone does better research before a customer meeting.

"Professional" only becomes part of the culture when meetings start on time, and actions are followed up.

"Entrepreneurial" only becomes part of the culture when people identify opportunities and take ownership.

"Results-oriented" only becomes part of the culture when teams honestly examine what works and what does not.

A value without behaviour remains just words. Behaviour that is repeated becomes culture.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

An organisation wants to become more customer-focused. The term is frequently used in presentations. Everyone agrees with it. Yet very little changes.

Sales conversations are prepared inconsistently. Customer needs are not always translated effectively into internal actions. Follow-up depends on personal discipline. Teams talk about the customer, but rarely discuss with real clarity and focus what the customer actually needs.

On paper, customer focus is a value. In behaviour, it has not yet become part of the culture.

The breakthrough comes when the organisation translates customer focus into three concrete behaviours:

1. Every important customer conversation is prepared with at least three in-depth customer questions.
2. Within 24 hours of every customer interaction, the customer's real needs are documented.
3. In every team meeting, one customer case is discussed: what did we learn, what did we do well, and what could we improve?

That may seem small. But it is precisely these small routines that change culture.

Not because people suddenly have different values, but because the desired behaviour becomes more visible, easier to discuss, and easier to repeat.

Coaching on the job makes cultural change tangible because behaviour is observed, practiced, and improved directly in the workplace. It is not values on paper that change the standard, but repeated workplace behaviour.

## REFLECTION QUESTIONS

1. What behaviour do we tolerate that does not actually match our ambition?
2. Where have our values not yet been translated sufficiently into concrete workplace behaviour?
3. Which unwritten rules shape our culture more strongly than our formal agreements?
4. Where do we avoid honest conversations because we fear discomfort?
5. What simple routine can we start this week to visibly strengthen our culture?

CHAPTER

# 05

# THE MINDSET OF THE PROFESSIONAL WHO MAKES AN IMPACT

STATEMENT

*Research by a well-known consulting firm in the United States indicates that companies perform better when they have current or former elite athletes on their management teams.*

A professional who makes an impact cannot be defined by a job title.

It is a way of looking, thinking, and acting.

It is the mindset of someone who understands that performance is not incidental, but consistent. Someone who does not wait for motivation, but relies on discipline. Someone who does not just talk about goals, but aligns their behaviour with them.

A number of characteristics clearly define this professional:

1. Goal orientation
2. Ownership
3. Determination
4. Teamwork
5. Discipline
6. Adaptability

### 7 Ability to perform under pressure

Not giving up when things go against you, but continuing to think under pressure and keep moving forward in the face of adversity.

These are not abstract qualities, but daily behavioural choices.

This mindset also means taking responsibility for your own development.

Many professionals implicitly wait for their organisation to make them better.

The professional who truly makes an impact turns that around. They ask: what can I do today to become sharper, more effective, and more valuable? That attitude changes everything.

Mental strength is not about toughness. It is not a mask, but the ability to remain honest, even under pressure. Not to hide behind excuses. To handle tension without freezing. To remain open to feedback without becoming defensive. That is mature performance capability.

I believe that this is exactly where the difference lies between people who perform well occasionally and those who become sustainably valuable.

Performing well occasionally can be achieved through talent, energy, or momentum.

Becoming sustainably valuable requires character. It requires the willingness to keep training yourself, especially when the outside world does not immediately see how much work goes into it.

The professional who makes an impact therefore does not seek comfort, but growth. Not applause, but progress. Not one-off success, but sustainable performance. That is precisely what makes this mindset so relevant to modern organisations.

For me, that mindset gains even greater strength from the lessons of elite sport.

A background in sport helps a business performance coach not only because they understand discipline, but also because they know from personal experience what performing under pressure truly requires.

Goal orientation, perseverance, team spirit, rhythm, recovery, energy management, and mental resilience are not abstract concepts when you have had to live them yourself.

That is what makes the translation from elite sport to business so relevant.

In both worlds, success does not come from a single moment of inspiration, but from repetition, correction, and the ability to remain sharp at crucial moments.

**A coach with elite-sport DNA therefore brings more than motivation: they bring credibility, performance discipline, and a deep understanding of what it takes to consistently elevate people and teams to a higher level.**

In that sense, an elite-sport background adds more than just a compelling story. It gives credibility to principles that, in business, are sometimes too quickly perceived as tough or uncomfortable.

Elite-sport discipline is then seen not only as a strength, but as a prerequisite for better performance.

Feedback is not experienced as rejection, but as an accelerator of progress.

Repetition is therefore not boring, but functional. Preparation is no longer a formality, but a form of respect for the moment when performance really matters.

This is exactly why a business performance coach with elite-sport DNA is so relevant to organisations.

Such a coach understands from personal experience what it means to work on rhythm, resilience, focus, and recovery.

They understand the tension between ambition and execution. They know how teams respond under pressure. And they have a sharper eye for the difference between talent and trainability.

The result is coaching that does not merely motivate, but above all creates movement and change.

For professionals, this is valuable because the translation into practice becomes very concrete. Not: how do I become a better version of myself in some abstract sense? But: what behaviour do I need to train in order to listen better today, make sharper

decisions, collaborate more effectively, and deliver more convincingly? The power of elite-sport thinking in business lies not in heroics, but in its practical applicability.

Those who take this mindset seriously often discover something important: performance and humanity do not have to weaken one another.

On the contrary. Clear standards, honest feedback, and rhythm can actually create greater safety, because people know where they stand and how they can grow.

A professional culture becomes stronger when high standards and trust go hand in hand.

### The Inner Standard

The central question for a professional who makes an impact is not: how do I come across well today? The real question is: what standard do I demand of myself, even when no one is there to correct me?

A professional who makes an impact distinguishes themselves above all through ownership. Not the passive ownership of saying that something is important, but the active ownership of taking action when no one is pushing. They do not wait for circumstances to become ideal. They look at what can be done, what the logical next step is, and what behaviour will improve the situation.

That mindset also requires self-discipline in uncomfortable situations. Receiving feedback when you would rather be proven right. Listening when you actually want to persuade. Preparing when you think you can rely on routine. That is precisely where growth takes place. Not in the moments when everything comes naturally, but in the moments when you consciously challenge your own comfort.

For organisations, this type of professional is invaluable. Not because they never make mistakes, but because they remain willing to learn. Coachability may well be one of the strongest predictors of growth. Someone who turns feedback into visibly dif-

ferent behaviour will improve faster than someone who relies solely on experience or talent.

A professional who makes an impact is also able to manage their energy. Not every moment requires the same level of intensity. Sometimes you need to accelerate, sometimes recover, and sometimes reflect. In many organisations, energy is still underestimated as a performance factor, even though fatigue directly affects sharpness, empathy, creativity, and decision-making.

The best professionals know their own patterns. They know when they are moving too fast, when they become defensive, when they procrastinate, and when they need to ask for help. Self-awareness does not make them softer; it makes them more effective. The better you can manage yourself, the more reliable you become for customers, colleagues, and leaders.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

Think of a professional who consistently has good ideas but struggles to finish them. They are smart, energetic, and committed, but quickly move on to the next topic. In a mediocre culture, this is accepted as creativity. In a performance culture, the conversation becomes sharper: what behaviour is needed to turn your talent into actual results?

The coaching question is not whether someone is motivated. The question is which routine is missing. Do they need to prioritize better? Ask for help sooner? Break commitments down into smaller steps? Make progress visible every week? Once behaviour becomes concrete, development can begin. That is when potential turns into reliability.

Impact, therefore, does not come from talent alone, but from the willingness to look honestly at your own patterns. The professional who can do that will improve faster than someone who mainly defends why something did not work.

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PART

# II

# LEADERSHIP AND TEAM PERFORMANCE


UAP

CHAPTER

# 06

# THE CAPTAIN: LEADERSHIP UNDER PRESSURE

STATEMENT

> *A true captain does not take the pressure out of the game, but brings so much calm under pressure that others are able to perform again.*

Under pressure, true leadership becomes visible, even when the leader says very little.

People observe more closely. They pay attention to tone, timing, composure, decisiveness, and presence. They do not only "read" what you say, but above all how you show up.

That is why the best leaders are rarely recognized by their volume, but by their stability.

Leadership only truly becomes visible when the pressure rises. In calm times, many forms of leadership can appear convincing. People have a plan, communicate clearly, and project a sense of control.

But only when uncertainty increases, resistance emerges, or results come under pressure does it become clear whether someone can truly lead.

The captain, the leader within an organisation, is not necessarily the person with the highest-ranking position. They are the person who provides direction when others start searching for

answers. Who brings calm without becoming passive. Who brings sharpness without becoming tense. Who makes decisions without becoming reckless.

That requires more than experience or intelligence. It requires mental strength.

### Intermezzo — Why Elite-Sport DNA Works in Business

The translation of elite sport into business works not because sport sounds romantic, but because elite sport makes behaviour visible that often remains hidden in organisations.

Under pressure, for example, the following qualities prove decisive:

- Mentality and perseverance
- Mental resilience
- Goal orientation and discipline
- Competitive mindset
- Teamwork and leadership
- Rapid decision-making
- Performing under pressure
- Energy management

Elite-sport DNA in business can be much more than an inspiring story: it gives organisations both the language and the behaviours needed to truly live up to higher standards.

Leadership under pressure begins with self-management. If you cannot manage yourself, you cannot lead a team.

A leader must recognize their emotions, challenge their assumptions, and be able to choose their response.

This sounds simple, but in practice it is rare. Many leaders are led by the situation rather than the other way around.

A captain also understands that leadership is not about knowing everything yourself.

Strong leadership creates clarity, energy, and responsibility in others. It asks the right questions, makes choices visible, and

keeps standards high. It gives people confidence, but does not allow a lack of commitment.

In elite sport, the captain is visible through their attitude and rhythm. The same applies in business. People are constantly reading their leader. Not only through their words, but certainly through their behaviour as well.

Doubt, delay, avoidance, and inconsistency spread incredibly quickly.

The same is true of calm, clarity, and decisiveness. Leadership is contagious.

A leader under pressure must be able to do three things:

1. Give meaning to the situation, so the team understands what is really going on.
2. Set boundaries, so energy is not lost to noise or panic.
3. Empower people, so they feel there is direction, confidence, and responsibility.

I have often seen teams get stuck not so much because of the content, but because of a lack of clear leadership.

Not because the people were not capable, but because no one held the bigger picture together. No one identified what really mattered. No one removed the noise. No one made clear what was expected of everyone at that moment.

That creates unrest, even among highly capable professionals.

Strong leaders understand that their behaviour shapes the climate. When they become smaller under pressure, the team becomes more constrained.

When they become defensive, feedback becomes dangerous.

When they remain calm and clear, they create space for maturity.

**Leadership Questions:**

1. How do I respond when the pressure suddenly increases?
2. What does my team learn primarily from my behaviour, rather than from my words?

3 Where do I project direction, and where do I unintentionally project doubt?

A captain does not need to have the final word on everything. In fact, strong leaders know when to give others space. But giving space is different from being absent. A team can only take responsibility when the boundaries are clear. Without direction, freedom can quickly turn into ambiguity.

Under pressure, the leader's most important task is often to reduce complexity. Not by making reality simpler than it is, but by distinguishing between what is essential and what is secondary. What is really going on? What requires attention right now? Which decision can no longer be postponed? Who needs to provide clarity on what?

This makes leadership practical. It lies in summarizing the tension, identifying the next step, protecting focus, and correcting behaviour that drains energy. The captain does not need to be the hero of the story. Their job is to enable the team to play again.

The captain also makes visible what can no longer be ignored. In many teams, there is a tendency to avoid tension, especially when everyone is busy. But unspoken tension does not disappear; it moves into corridor conversations, delays, and cynicism. Strong leadership brings the conversation back to the table.

Tone is essential in this. A leader can be direct without becoming harsh. They can confront without causing damage. They can provide direction without taking away all freedom. This requires practice, but it is precisely through this practice that leadership under pressure gains credibility.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A team misses two important targets and tension begins to rise.

Some people want to launch new actions immediately, others blame the market, while others withdraw. At a moment like this, the leader determines the quality of what happens next. If the leader gets caught up in the panic, the organisation becomes

more constrained. If the leader brings calm and direction, the team can start thinking clearly again.

The captain first clarifies what actually happened. Then they identify what can and cannot be influenced. Next, they make choices: which customers should be prioritized, which assumptions need to be tested, and which agreements need to change from today onward? That sequence creates a sense of control without denying the pressure.

Leadership under pressure is therefore not about shouting louder, but about organizing reality in such a way that people can act effectively again. That is the strength of the captain.

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CHAPTER

# 07

# COACHING ON THE JOB: LEARNING IN THE REAL GAME

STATEMENT

> *Development only becomes valuable when someone experiences the difference between knowing what could be improved and actually doing it better.*

The workplace is the most honest training ground there is.

That is where it becomes visible how someone listens, responds, sells, collaborates, leads, and makes decisions under pressure.

That is where you see not the theory of performance, but its reality in practice.

That is what makes coaching on the job such a powerful instrument.

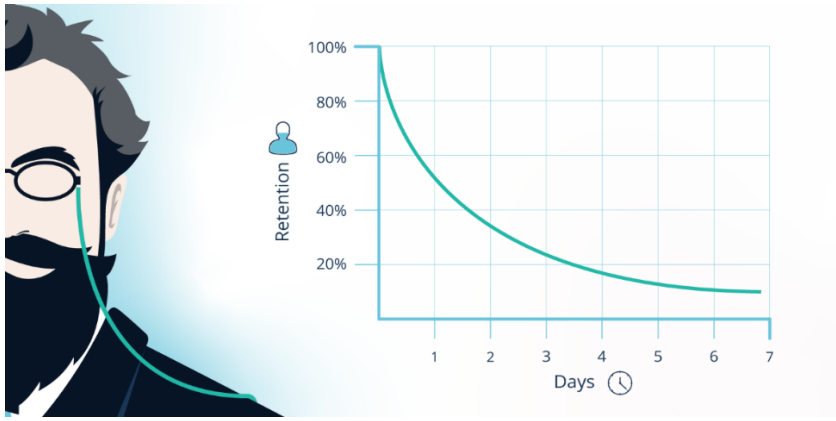
Many development programs fail not because the content is poor, but because the transfer into practice is missing.

People attend a training session, become inspired, take notes, and return to their work. There, the pressures of everyday business are waiting for them.

Within just a few days, a large part of the new information has already been forgotten.

What remains is good intention without behavioural change.

The graph below shows how quickly we forget what we have formally learned: five days after a training session, we have already forgotten 80%.




This Ebbinghaus graph illustrates that when you learn something for the first time, the information fades exponentially without reinforcement.

In other words, you lose most of your newly acquired knowledge in the first few days, after which the rate of loss begins to decrease.

**Coaching on the job helps you learn by putting acquired knowledge into practice.**

Learning does not take place at a distance from reality, but right in the middle of practice.

In real conversations. In challenging customer dynamics.

In meetings where something is at stake. In teams that have to deliver.

That is where learning becomes concrete, immediate, and relevant.

**Coaching on the job is based on a fundamental principle: doing is the best way of thinking.**

People only truly change when insight is connected to experience.

Not only understanding what could be improved, but immediately practicing it, adjusting it, and embedding it. This not only accelerates learning, but also increases ownership.

### Training versus coaching: the real difference

The comparison below makes the distinction clear. Training remains valuable, but coaching on the job primarily accelerates the application of learning in everyday practice.

| Feature | Traditional training | Coaching on the job |
|---|---|---|
| Focus | Knowledge transfer and structured learning | Skill development and performance improvement in daily practice |
| Approach | Often group-based | Personalized, 1-to-1 or in small teams |
| Timing | Often a separate event | Ongoing process within daily work |
| Feedback | Often delayed | Direct, continuous, task- and behavior-focused |
| Application | Transfer to the workplace happens later | Direct application in daily practice |
| Individualization | Limited | High |
| Objective | Achieve specific learning objectives | Improve performance directly and strengthen behavior sustainably |

Many organisations invest in training, and rightly so. But training alone is rarely enough to create sustainable behavioural change.

Traditional training is often structured, group-based, and focused on knowledge transfer.

Coaching on the job is more personal, more flexible, and directly connected to the reality of the workplace.

**Where training helps people understand what they could do better, coaching on the job helps them actually do it better immediately.**

That difference may seem small, but in practice it is significant. Training is often a separate event. Coaching on the job is an ongoing process embedded in daily work.

Training often involves delayed feedback. Coaching provides direct, continuous, and task-specific feedback.

**Training usually still requires the learning to be transferred to the workplace. Coaching takes place in the workplace itself, in real time, which shortens the learning curve and improves knowledge retention.**

Precisely because coaching is integrated into daily work, it is often more cost-effective as well. Less learning time is lost. The translation into behaviour is more immediate, and internal expertise can be used more effectively. This means that coaching on the job is not the softer form of development, but often the most performance-oriented one.

For employees, this means that development feels far less disconnected from reality. Instead of first learning something and only later discovering whether it works, people immediately see the relationship between their behaviour and its effect.

A better opening question in a customer conversation.

A sharper summary in a meeting.

A calmer response under pressure.

Because these effects are immediately noticeable, ownership also increases. People experience more quickly that they themselves can influence their performance.

Coaching on the job also strengthens professionals' self-confidence.

Not by simply telling them that they are doing well, but by allowing them to experience that, with focused guidance and adjustment, they can genuinely improve.

That makes development more credible. It reduces the gap between potential and results. It also helps professionals become less dependent on external validation, because they learn from their own experience what works in practice.

For organisations, the benefits are even broader. When coaching on the job is used effectively, it improves not only individual

skills, but also productivity, collaboration, retention, and commercial effectiveness.

People become effective more quickly. Teams learn from mistakes sooner, and managers gain greater insight into the behaviours that either strengthen or hinder performance.

At the same time, the organisation builds a culture in which feedback, preparation, and continuous improvement become increasingly normal.

### Why This Approach Sticks So Much Better

Traditional training certainly has value, especially when an organisation wants to introduce a common language, models, or basic knowledge. But without practice in the workplace, there is a high risk that what has been learned will fade.

Coaching on the job breaks exactly that pattern. The context is real, the relevance is immediate, and the feedback is linked to observable behaviour.

As a result, not only is the knowledge retained better, but, more importantly, the application becomes stronger.

The well-known 70-20-10 approach reinforces this. Most development takes place in the workplace itself. Not in classrooms, but through challenging assignments, collaboration, feedback, reflection, and experimentation. That does not mean that formal training has no value.

It does mean that training without application delivers little return.

The 70-20-10 approach is a theory developed by Charles Jennings.

It is a model that describes how effective learning can be structured.

The underlying principle of the 70:20:10 model is that learning itself is not the central focus, but the performance that results from learning. Learning, in whatever form, is a means of achieving that goal.

70:20:10 is more than a model. It is a movement that aims to put not learning, *but performance back at the centre*, and to use training and development as a means to achieve that goal.

**70:20:10 represents three ways of learning:**

70% learning in the workplace

20% social learning, for example through interaction with colleagues

10% formal learning, such as training courses, education, and e-learning.

For leaders and organisations, the lesson is clear: do not develop people simply by giving them knowledge, but by guiding them more effectively in their real working context.

By observing them in practice, asking questions, giving feedback, reflecting behaviour back to them, and practicing where it truly matters.

That is coaching on the job. And that is why it is so much more effective than development at a distance.

Coaching on the job is also not a control mechanism. It is not a way of constantly looking over people's shoulders.

It is a way of unlocking potential. Because a coach works close to the reality of the job, they can identify small behavioural changes that can have a major impact.

A better opening to a conversation. A sharper question. A better-planned follow-up. A different way of using silence. A clearer decision in a meeting.

These are often not spectacular interventions, but precise adjustments.

The impact is often greater than organisations expect beforehand.

One sharper qualification question can completely change the quality of a sales conversation.

One consistent agreement about preparation can visibly raise the standard of an entire team. One leader who learns to respond more calmly under pressure can transform the dynamics of a whole department.

Coaching on the job is effective because it does not depend on big words, but on precise behavioural choices that can be repeated every day.

This also makes this form of coaching a bridge between people and results.

Employees feel that they are being taken more seriously because their development is connected to their real working context.

Leaders gain a more concrete way to strengthen behaviour without falling into micromanagement.

At the same time, organisations begin to see that coaching is not a peripheral cost, but an investment that directly improves execution, collaboration, and results.

### What coaching on the job asks of leaders

The effectiveness of coaching on the job depends heavily on the quality of leadership. Leaders need to be willing to observe without taking over too quickly. They must be able to point out facts without being judgmental. They need to identify small areas for improvement rather than overwhelming people with feedback. Coaching on the job should be delivered by an external party.

Consistency is more important here than intensity. One focused intervention per week, sustained consistently, often has more impact than an occasional large session.

I have seen several times how one small intervention can make a major difference.

An account manager who presented his solution too quickly in conversations, before the customer had even fully explained what was really going on. When he learned to stay longer in the qualification phase and ask one additional layer of deeper questions, not only did the quality of his conversations improve, but so did his conversion rate. Not because he suddenly became a different person, but because one behavioural detail changed the entire game.

That is exactly where good coaching resembles elite sport. The best coaches do not always change the whole player. Sometimes they change one detail that influences the entire performance.

### The Benefits for Employees and Organisations

For employees, the value is significant. Coaching on the job accelerates skill development, builds self-confidence, strengthens autonomy, and helps people deal more effectively with pressure and complexity.

Because the guidance is tailored to their own tasks and goals, employees feel taken more seriously, better supported, and become competent more quickly.

This increases motivation, job satisfaction, and their sense of future perspective.

For organisations, the benefits are just as relevant.

Coaching on the job leads to higher productivity, fewer mistakes, better quality of execution, and stronger individual and team performance.

It improves communication, time management, problem-solving ability, and decision-making.

It also contributes to higher retention, because people see that the organisation is investing in their growth and, as a result, feel greater loyalty and connection.

This means that coaching on the job touches on something bigger than development alone.

It influences the performance culture of an organisation. Direct feedback accelerates improvement.

Better collaboration reduces frustration. Greater ownership and motivation improve the quality of execution.

And when people feel seen and valued, not only does energy in the workplace increase, but often commercial awareness, customer satisfaction, and conversion power improve as well.

Coaching on the job is therefore not just a learning tool. It is a way of connecting performance, culture, and commercial effectiveness.

That is what makes it so valuable for leaders and organisations: you are not only developing people, you are simultaneously raising the standard by which they work and deliver together.

### Practical Principle

Good coaching on the job often follows this rhythm:

1. Observe without taking over too quickly.
2. Describe what was actually visible.
3. Ask deeper questions about intention and impact.
4. Choose one or two concrete areas for improvement.
5. Apply them again immediately in practice.

**Coaching on the job works primarily because learning is not separated from the context in which performance has to take place.** A customer conversation, an internal meeting, or a difficult decision-making moment always contains more information than a training room can replicate. You see tone, timing, body language, preparation, hesitation, and impact all at the same time.

That is why the role of the coach is so precise. Not to improve everything at once, but to identify the one behavioural detail that can make the biggest difference at that moment. Sometimes it is a better opening question. Sometimes it is learning to tolerate silence. Sometimes it is summarizing more sharply before presenting a solution. Small corrections can have a major commercial impact.

For the organisation, there is also a second effect: learning becomes visible. Colleagues see that behaviour can be discussed, that feedback is normal, and that improvement does not only begin after formal training. In this way, coaching on the job becomes not only a development tool, but also a culture accelerator.

**A major advantage of coaching in practice is that the feedback has immediate meaning. The professional does not have to**

**translate theory into work, because the work situation itself becomes the learning moment**. As a result, feedback becomes less abstract and the likelihood increases that new behaviour will actually stick.

For leaders, this means they need to learn how to observe well.

Not only the outcomes, but also the behaviour that causes those outcomes. Where did someone lose control of the situation? Where was an opportunity missed? Where was trust created? Where were assumptions made too quickly? Leaders who observe in this way can coach much more effectively.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

An account manager often loses depth in customer conversations because he moves to his solution too quickly. In a training session, he fully understands that he needs to ask more probing questions. But only when a coach sits alongside him, observes the conversation, and immediately afterwards highlights one specific moment does the learning point become truly visible.

The coach does not say: you need to listen better. He identifies exactly what happened: after the first signal of urgency, you immediately started presenting, while the customer had not yet explained who was involved internally.

In the next meeting, the account manager practices going one layer deeper in the qualification phase before presenting a proposal. That small change in behaviour transforms the conversation.

That is how coaching on the job works: not in a grand, vague, or theoretical way, but precisely where behaviour directly influences the result.

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CHAPTER

# 08

# BUILDING CHAMPION TEAMS

STATEMENT

> *A championship team is not created when everyone thinks the same, but when everyone fully contributes their unique strengths in service of the team.*

A championship team is rarely the team with the most stars. It is usually the team in which individual strengths are aligned most effectively.

That may sound less exciting than talent, but it is far more powerful. Talent attracts attention. Alignment wins games.

A championship team is not created simply because a group of talented people happen to come together.

Talent is valuable, but without role clarity, trust, and discipline, talent becomes fragmented.

A team only wins when individual strengths serve a shared goal.

Most teams function reasonably well as long as circumstances are favourable. The difference between a good team and a championship team becomes visible under pressure.

When deadlines get closer, when a major deal is at stake, when results disappoint.

That is when it becomes clear whether the team strengthens or weakens one another.

Championship teams have clear agreements, high standards, and open communication.

They know what the mission is, who is responsible for what, and how success is measured. They are willing to challenge one another without damaging relationships. They make feedback normal, not exceptional.

And they understand that trust is not soft, but functional: without trust, speed, honesty, and decisiveness decline.

A strong team also requires sacrifice.

Not everyone can always get their own way. Sometimes an individual preference has to be set aside for the sake of the collective result.

In elite sport, that is taken for granted. In business, it is sometimes forgotten.

But the same principle applies there: without the willingness to play in service of the whole, a team remains nothing more than a collection of individuals.

I have seen teams with a great deal of experience, capability, and good intentions still perform below their potential.

Not because of a lack of knowledge, but because of a lack of genuine alignment.

People did not understand one another's roles well enough.

Expectations remained implicit. Frustrations were left unspoken.

Responsibilities were shifted back and forth. That creates noise. And noise erodes performance.

Championship teams train not only on content, but also on collaboration, difficult conversations, alignment, rhythm, and recovery after setbacks. It is precisely this social and mental training that makes the difference when everyone is technically good enough.

### Team Questions

1 Is it truly clear within our team who can be held accountable for what?

2 Do we address tension early enough, or only once it escalates?

3 Which team habits strengthen our performance, and which ones weaken it?

Championship teams usually have a high tolerance for differences, but a low tolerance for lack of commitment. People are allowed to think differently, see things differently, and bring different strengths to the team. That makes the team stronger. But when it comes to commitment, preparation, agreements, and responsibility, there is no ambiguity.

That distinction is important. Many teams try to avoid tension by keeping everything friendly. But real collaboration requires making tension functional. Not making it personal, but keeping the focus on performance. Not trying to prove who is right, but raising the collective standard.

I experienced exactly what that can mean at the highest level during our preparation for the 1990 Hockey World Cup.

### When Preparation Becomes a Team Standard

In the months leading up to the World Cup, we became obsessed with every detail that could make a difference

Nothing was too small to discuss. Where exactly did you want to receive the ball? If you made a particular run, did you want the pass directly onto your stick, slightly ahead of you, or wider so you could turn immediately?

If I passed to a teammate's right side, for example, there was a reason: I had seen that he could turn immediately because his opponent was positioned towards his weaker side.

Those details may sound tiny. At the highest level, they weren't.

One of our agreements, for example, was that when I passed the ball to a teammate on his right side, it was because I had seen that he could turn in that direction straight away. His opponent was positioned more on his weaker side, which created a small but important advantage.

And if that agreed pattern did not happen, even once, the discussion could become intense. Not because we wanted to blame each other, but because we held each other to an exceptionally high standard. Sometimes the conversations were sharp. Sometimes they were uncomfortable. But they always had one simple purpose: to become even better and to win that world title.

Our coach, Hans Jorritsma (RIP 2026), was an extreme perfectionist. Every potentially decisive detail was repeated again and again. Hans was also a pioneer in introducing video analysis into hockey — and perhaps even into elite sport as a whole in the Netherlands.

At that time, video analysis was nothing like it is today. There were no digital clips, no instant replays on laptops, no data dashboards. Everything was done with a VHS video recorder: rewind, fast-forward, rewind, fast-forward. Together in small, selected groups, we analysed the attacking and defensive penalty corners of our opponents, as well as our own. In Dutch field hockey, penalty corners have always been a powerful weapon, and we treated them with the seriousness they deserved.

On the day of the final, Hans wanted us to arrive at the stadium well in advance. So we left the hotel with plenty of time to spare. But when we arrived at the stadium, the gate was closed.

For a brief moment, there was a sense of uncertainty. Ouch — now what?

But this was exactly where preparation showed its real value. Because we had rehearsed so much, discussed so much and prepared for so many possible situations, this unexpected incident did not disturb our concentration. It did not create panic. It did not take us out of our rhythm.

We stayed calm, stayed focused and stayed connected as a team.

And later that day, we won the world title in the lion's den: in Lahore, Pakistan, against the overwhelming favourites, Pakistan.

In strong teams, feedback is not an incident. It is maintenance. Just as an elite sports team discusses tactics, sharpens movement patterns, and repeats routines, teams in business must keep

training the way they work together. If you only challenge one another when things go wrong, you are already too late.

A championship team also has the ability to recover. Not every meeting goes well, not every decision is the right one, and not every collaboration runs smoothly. The difference lies in how quickly a team recovers. Does the team learn, speak openly, and realign? Or does it remain stuck in frustration and old stories?

Strong teams need rituals. Short evaluations, clear check-ins, agreements on decision-making, and moments when tension can be discussed safely but directly. Such rituals may seem small, but they ensure that collaboration does not remain dependent on chance or personal chemistry.

Precisely that distinction is important. Many teams try to avoid tension by keeping everything friendly. But real collaboration requires you to make tension functional. Not personal, but focused on performance. Not about proving who is right, but about raising the collective standard.

Teams need to keep training. If you only challenge one another when things go wrong, you are already too late.

A championship team also needs the ability to recover. Not every meeting goes well, not every decision is the right one, and not every collaboration runs smoothly.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A team consists of strong individuals, but everyone mainly works from their own agenda. Sales makes ambitious promises, delivery feels involved too late, and marketing believes the proposition is being used incorrectly. No one has bad intentions, but the team is not playing as one. Ultimately, the customer feels the internal friction.

A championship team would not allow this to continue. It discusses roles, handover moments, and shared standards. Who is allowed to promise what? When should delivery be involved? Which message to the customer takes the lead? These agreements reduce friction and increase speed.

Teams do not become champions simply because everyone works together nicely. They become champions because individual strengths are aligned and the collective game becomes more important than personal preferences.



*1990: world champion field hockey in Lahore, Pakistan.*

Final: Pakistan – Netherlands: 1-3

CHAPTER

# 09

# PERFORMING UNDER PRESSURE WITHOUT FREEZING

STATEMENT

> *Under pressure, you rarely win with more energy; you usually win with greater control.*

Pressure does not destroy anything that was not already there. Pressure reveals what has not yet been trained enough.

That can be confronting, but also liberating. Because it means that pressure is not only a threat, but also a mirror. An opportunity to see where you still have room to grow.

Pressure is part of performance. Anyone who wants to make an impact, win deals, carry responsibility, or lead at a high level will have to deal with pressure. So the question is not how to avoid pressure, but how to learn to handle it effectively.

Many people respond to pressure by narrowing their focus. They start talking louder, acting faster, listening less, or postponing decisions.

Some become controlling. Others avoid confrontation. The core of the problem is that pressure narrows the way we think. You see less, feel more, and react faster. That is human, but not always effective.

Performing under pressure requires training and, above all, coaching.

It requires developing routines, self-awareness, and mental calm.

Athletes use rituals, preparation, breathing, focus, and recovery.

In business, you can apply exactly the same principles.

Before important conversations, pitches, negotiations, and leadership moments.

One of the clearest examples of the relationship between preparation and pressure can be seen in something millions of people have watched: a penalty shoot-out. And every time I watch one, I am still surprised by what happens before the first penalty is even taken.

Even today, I still find it remarkable how many football teams, club sides as well as national teams, react when extra time has finished and the referee signals that the match will be decided by a penalty shoot-out.

Instead of seeing confidence, I often see uncertainty.

Players gather in a nervous circle.

An assistant coach rushes around with a crumpled piece of paper.

The order of the penalty takers is discussed at the very last minute.

Sometimes players are even asked whether they feel like taking one.

I have never understood that.

A penalty shoot-out should never be improvised.

It should have been decided long before kick-off.

Of course, there are exceptions. If a player has been carrying an injury throughout the match or has had a particularly poor game, you might reconsider. But that player would have to feel genuinely unable to perform.

Otherwise, the decision should already have been made.

Before the match begins, every player should know exactly:

Who takes the first penalty.

Who takes the second.

Who takes the third.

And who is prepared if the penalty series continues beyond five penalties.

Nothing should be left to chance.

Now, I fully appreciate that you cannot perfectly recreate the pressure of walking towards the penalty spot in front of 80,000 spectators while millions watch on television.

But pressure itself isn't the point. Preparation is.

The better prepared you are, the less mental energy you waste making decisions when the pressure is at its highest.

One of the finest examples of preparation came during the 2014 FIFA World Cup.

Just before the end of extra time in the quarter-final against Costa Rica, Dutch coach Louis van Gaal made a substitution that surprised almost everyone.

He replaced his first-choice goalkeeper, Jasper Cillessen, with reserve goalkeeper Tim Krul.

It looked like a gamble. It wasn't. It was preparation.

Van Gaal had anticipated that the match might be decided on penalties, and Tim Krul had specifically prepared for that scenario.

The result?

Krul saved two penalties and became one of the heroes of the tournament.

Even more interesting is the preparation that many goalkeepers do before a penalty shoot-out.

You'll often see a water bottle with a small sticker attached to it.

On that sticker are notes about the opposing players.

Number 10 usually shoots low to the goalkeeper's left.

Number 7 prefers the top-right corner.

Number 9 tends to wait for the goalkeeper to move first.

Preparation becomes intelligence.

And then a fascinating psychological game begins.

The goalkeeper knows where the player usually shoots.

The player knows the goalkeeper probably knows.

The goalkeeper knows the player knows that he knows.

The player knows the goalkeeper knows that he knows...

Still with me?

At that point, the battle is no longer about technique alone.

It becomes a battle of confidence.

My advice is surprisingly simple.

If you have prepared well...

If you trust your technique...

If you have practiced thousands of penalties...

Then don't start inventing something new.

Trust your preparation.

Trust your technique.

Focus on one thing only.

Scoring.

Whether your penalty wins the World Cup or decides a local cup final, the technique required is exactly the same.

The pressure may feel different.

The task is not.

People often believe that extraordinary moments require extraordinary performances.

In reality, extraordinary moments demand ordinary skills executed exceptionally well.

Imagine you score the winning penalty in a World Cup final.

The following week, you still pay exactly the same price for your groceries as everyone else.

And imagine someone tells you you'll receive a €1 million bonus if you score.

Will that suddenly improve your technique?

Will you strike the ball harder?

Will your accuracy magically increase?

Of course not.

Money doesn't improve execution.

Preparation does.

The legendary Dutch footballer Johan Cruyff once said:

"I've never seen a bag of money score a goal."

Neither have I.

Because under pressure, people don't rise to the occasion.

They fall back on the level of their preparation.

The business lesson is exactly the same.

Pressure does not suddenly give you capabilities you did not have before. If anything, it exposes the quality of your preparation. When the decisive customer presentation begins, when the negotiation becomes difficult, or when a crisis hits, that is not the moment to invent your approach. The preparation should already have been done.

Preparation does not remove pressure. It removes uncertainty.

It is important to understand that calm is not the same as slowness. Calm is inner stability.

It is the ability to stay clear-headed while the outside world becomes hectic. To focus your attention on what you can influence. To carry tension without slipping into panic or rigidity.

If you want to perform well under pressure, you should not wait until the pressure arrives. You need to practice in advance how you respond to it. What signals does your body give you? Which thoughts take over? Where do you lose your sharpness? Once you become aware of these patterns, you can turn pressure from an enemy into fuel.

I have seen professionals who were strong in terms of content, but lost their timing under pressure.

They started talking too much, defending too much, or trying to persuade too quickly. Not because they were poor performers, but because the pressure narrowed their natural strengths. That is why self-awareness is so important. If you know how you respond under pressure, you can adjust sooner.

### Ritual Under Pressure

Before important moments, three simple questions can help:

1. What is truly important here?
2. What can I influence right now?
3. What behaviour will help me most at this moment?

Pressure becomes dangerous when people try to deny it.

Someone may appear calm, while internally the tension continues to rise. It is better to recognize the pressure and put it into words. What am I feeling? Where is my attention narrowing? What reflex is taking over? This kind of self-observation is not a weakness, but a performance skill.

The same applies to teams. A team that cannot identify what is happening under pressure often starts working harder without performing better. People fall back into old patterns, hold more meetings, send more emails, and increase control. But if no one slows down to see what is truly needed, the pressure only multiplies.

The skill is therefore not to organize pressure away, but to build routines that make pressure manageable. Prepare, prioritize, breathe, evaluate briefly, confirm roles, and recover after moments of tension. It sounds simple, but especially under pressure, simple routines outperform complicated plans.

Under pressure, attention is your most valuable asset. Where does your attention go? To fear of losing, the need for control, the judgment of others, or the next effective action? The professional who can direct their attention retains greater freedom in how they respond.

Recovery is also part of performing under pressure. Moving straight on after an intense moment may seem tough, but it is not always wise. Teams need short moments to decompress, learn, and refocus. Without recovery, tension accumulates and the quality of decision-making gradually declines.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A leader notices that under pressure, he starts speaking faster and listening less effectively. Under normal circumstances, he is collaborative and connecting, but when tension rises, he becomes more directive and impatient. His team experiences this as control, which causes people to take less initiative. As a result, the pressure does not decrease; it increases.

The breakthrough begins with awareness. The leader learns to recognize his own signals: an increase in pace, shorter questions, and quicker judgments. He then chooses a simple routine: first summarize, then ask questions, then decide. Not because he needs to become less decisive, but because this allows his decisiveness to have a more effective impact.

Performing better under pressure therefore often does not mean doing more. It means learning to control your first reflex so that your strongest qualities remain available.

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CHAPTER

# 10

# HOW DO YOU INCREASE THE COMMERCIAL STRENGTH OF YOUR COMPANY?

STATEMENT

*Commercial strength does not begin with chasing harder, but with looking more sharply, aligning better, and executing more consistently.*

Commercial effectiveness is the difference between simply being present in the market and actually making an impact in the market.

Many organisations are visible. Fewer organisations are truly sharp.

And it is precisely that sharpness that ultimately determines whether effort turns into revenue and whether activity turns into results.

Commercial effectiveness is much more than having a strong sales department. It is an organisation's ability to recognize opportunities, truly understand customers, position propositions clearly, and consistently convert value into results.

That requires alignment between people, processes, leadership, and mindset.

Many organisations believe that commercial growth mainly depends on market conditions or the talent of a few strong individuals. Of course, those factors matter.

But sustainable commercial strength is created when an organisation systematically improves its preparation, positioning, conversation skills, follow-up, and decision-making.

The field is where it happens.

That is where strategy meets reality. That is where it becomes clear whether people are genuinely well supported.

Whether propositions are clear. Whether teams have enough sharpness. Whether leaders understand what commercial practice requires. The field is like a mirror. It does not show what you intend, but what you are actually capable of.

An organisation with strong commercial effectiveness ensures that people in the field do not simply work harder, but also work smarter. They understand their customers better. They have access to the right insights. They are stronger in conversations. They recognize interests more quickly. They are better able to switch between relationship, content, and decision-making.

What strikes me is that organisations still individualize commercial performance too often. As if success mainly depends on a few natural talents.

But commercial effectiveness is absolutely a team sport.

Marketing, leadership, positioning, delivery, account management, and business development constantly influence one another.

When those elements are not aligned, you lose strength, even when the individual professionals are good.

I have seen organisations where ambition was high, the proposition appeared strong, and people worked hard, yet too little commercial acceleration was achieved.

Not because the market offered no opportunities, but because too much energy was lost internally between departments, assumptions, and only partially aligned messages.

In that situation, you are essentially a team with plenty of talent on the field, but without a strong game plan.

Commercial effectiveness can be trained and, above all, coached.

That may be the most important message. It is not an innate talent possessed by a fortunate few.

It is a combination of discipline, method, coaching, and rhythm. And just as in elite sport, anyone who wants to improve consistently must train consistently.

**Commercial Check:**

- Do we understand our customer better than our competitors do?
- Is our proposition truly sharp, or does it mainly make sense internally?
- Where are we currently losing commercial energy without generating sufficient return?

Commercial effectiveness begins with sharp positioning. An organisation must not only know what it sells, but above all which problem it solves, why that problem matters, and why it is credible in helping to solve it. Without that clarity, selling quickly becomes explaining rather than persuading.

Commercial effectiveness also requires discipline in follow-up. Many opportunities are not lost in the first conversation, but in the period that follows. Responding too late, failing to summarize clearly, not defining a concrete next step, or lacking visibility into the decision-making process: these are small mistakes that together can have a major impact.

Anyone who wants to strengthen commercial effectiveness should not only look at the number of leads or customer visits. Also look at the quality of the qualification phase, the clarity of the value proposition, the speed of follow-up, and the extent to which the team learns from both won and lost opportunities. That is often where the real gains are made.

Commercial effectiveness requires the entire organisation to understand how value is created. Sales cannot carry on its own what marketing positions unclearly, what delivery fails to deliver, or what leadership does not consistently support. The customer

experiences the sum of all these elements. That is why commercial effectiveness is never just a sales issue.

A practical way to assess this is to review both won and lost deals. Not to look for someone to blame, but to identify patterns.

Where were we chosen? Where did we lose momentum? Where was our value not concrete enough? Where did trust play a greater role than price? This kind of analysis makes commercial growth more manageable.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A software company has a strong product, but is growing more slowly than expected. The sales team works hard, marketing generates leads, and management focuses heavily on activity.

Yet conversion rates remain disappointing. A closer analysis reveals that customers do not understand the value proposition clearly enough and that follow-up after conversations is too non-committal.

The solution is not simply to make more calls or run more campaigns. First, the commercial standard needs to be raised.

Which customer problems can we demonstrably solve? Which questions must always be asked during the qualification phase? What kind of follow-up should each prospect receive, and when? How do we learn from lost deals? That discipline creates higher-quality execution in the field.

Commercial effectiveness grows when the organisation does not simply chase harder, but plays smarter. That requires method, rhythm, and coaching.

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CHAPTER

# 11

# FROM CUSTOMER TO FAN

STATEMENT

> *When you turn customers into fans, you do not just sell more; you build a market position that competitors find much harder to copy.*

A customer buys from you. A fan trusts you, remembers you, and helps you move forward.

That difference may seem small, but commercially it is enormous. Organisations rarely achieve sustainable growth through isolated transactions alone. They grow through relationships that become stronger rather than weaker.

Every organisation wants customers. But the organisations that truly grow build more than a customer base. They build fans.

People and companies that do not just buy, but stay. That trust you. That recommend you. That see you as a partner rather than a supplier.

Moving from customer to fan requires a different way of thinking.

Not just driving transactions, but deepening relationships.

Not just delivering what was agreed, but understanding what truly matters to the customer.

Not just satisfaction, but engagement.

Fans do not emerge by chance. They are created when an organisation consistently delivers value, shows genuine interest, listens well, and manages expectations intelligently.

The customer then feels that they are not working with a company that mainly wants to sell, but with one that genuinely wants to contribute.

Emotion also plays a bigger role than many business professionals are willing to admit. Trust, positive energy, goodwill, credibility, and reliability are not soft concepts.

They have direct commercial value.

People prefer to do business with organisations that are clear, consistent, and easy to work with.

The step from customer to fan therefore requires more than a good product. It requires an experience of professionalism, attention, and trust.

Those who understand this do not just build revenue, but sustainable growth.

I have often seen organisations focus too heavily on winning new customers and too little on deepening existing relationships.

Yet that is often where a huge hidden growth opportunity lies.

Not by selling harder, but by understanding better, delivering more consistently, and remaining more relevant.

### Fan Factor

Ask yourself:

1. Where do customers feel that we truly understand them?
2. Where are we pleasantly predictable and professionally reliable?
3. What do we do that makes customers spontaneously talk about us?

Fans are created when customers notice that you look beyond the assignment itself. That does not mean you have to do everything for free or always be available. It means that you think along with the customer, look ahead, and take responsibility for the value

you promise. Professionalism then becomes something the customer can actually feel.

The journey from customer to fan is built on consistency. One good experience is positive, but it does not yet create relationship capital. Trust grows when customers repeatedly experience that you do what you say, communicate clearly, be honest about risks, and do not disappear once the contract has been signed.

For commercial organisations, this is crucial. A fan reduces the cost of sales, increases the likelihood of repeat business, and opens the door to new relationships. But that only happens when customer experience is not treated as the responsibility of one department, but as a shared standard across the entire organisation.

Turning customers into fans also requires active expectation management. Much disappointment does not arise because the quality is poor, but because expectations remain unclear. A customer who knows what to expect, when to expect it, and why, experiences greater control and trust. That has direct commercial value.

Fans are also often created in difficult moments. When something goes wrong, the customer sees who you really are.

Are you honest? Do you act quickly? Do you take responsibility? Do you communicate clearly? It is precisely in those moments that trust can become stronger than when everything simply goes according to plan.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A customer is satisfied with a project, but has not yet become a fan. The delivery was good, the invoice was correct, and all commitments were met. Yet something is missing. The customer feels supported, but not truly surprised or moved forward. That is the difference between delivering correctly and building relational value.

A fan is created when the supplier looks just a little further. A risk is identified in advance. An opportunity is shared before the cus-

tomer asks for it. An evaluation does not focus only on satisfaction, but also on how the collaboration can create more value. The customer then feels that there is genuine ownership on both sides.



Turning a customer into a fan is therefore not a marketing trick. It is the result of repeated professional behaviour that deepens trust.

CHAPTER

# 12

# THE ART OF BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT

STATEMENT

*Good business development often looks natural from the outside, but behind the scenes it is always the result of discipline, preparation, timing, and a genuine intrinsic interest in the customer as a professional, as a person, and in their business.*

Business development is not a hunting technique. It is a growth discipline.

Anyone who reduces it to acquisition is missing half the game. True business development is about seeing, sensing, building, timing, and positioning.

Business development is often narrowed down to acquisition. But real business development is broader. It is about identifying growth opportunities, developing relationships, reading market movements, building trust, and positioning strategically. It is the art of winning deals today without blocking opportunities for tomorrow.

Strong business developers understand that growth does not come from simply pushing harder. They know when to accelerate and when to slow down. When to ask more questions and when to focus primarily on listening. They have a strong sense of tim-

ing. They build relationships before there is any immediate urgency.

Networking plays an important role in this. Not as superficial business-card collecting, but as building genuine connections. **People remember not only what you say, but above all who you are.** Whether you are reliable. Whether you bring positive energy. Whether you keep your commitments. Whether you show genuine interest.

The goodwill factor is also an underestimated commercial asset. Not in the sense of trying to be charming in order to be liked, but in the deeper sense of creating trust. People prefer to do business with those who are authentic, well prepared, helpful, and consistent.

Business development is not only a commercial discipline, but also a discipline of character. You build market position through expertise, but also through behaviour. Not by acting, but by being authentic. Good business development then feels simple, even though a great deal of discipline and control lies behind it.

I strongly believe that the best business developers are rarely the loudest people in the room. More often, they are the people who observe carefully, listen sharply, connect the dots, and sense the right timing. They understand that being present in the market is important, but being relevant in the relationship is even more important.

### Business Development Questions

- Am I mainly focused on broadcasting my message, or am I genuinely building relationships and insight?
- Do I have a clear view of where the real growth opportunities lie?
- Which of my behaviours increase trust, and which ones reduce it?

Business development requires the ability to remain relevant today without sacrificing tomorrow's relationship. That means

that sometimes you should not push, but invest in understanding. Those who focus only on short-term revenue often miss the strategic opportunity that may prove far more valuable later.

A good business developer builds context. They understand what is happening in the market, which moves customers are making, where budgets are shifting, and which topics are becoming more important at board level. As a result, they do not simply bring something to the table; they can help give meaning to issues the customer is still trying to make sense of.

That also makes business development a form of leadership. You help the other person look more clearly at growth, risk, and timing. You are not only selling a solution; you are helping to determine direction. This creates a level of trust that goes beyond a single commercial opportunity.

Business development requires patience without passivity. You build relationships, while still maintaining direction. You listen, without losing sight of your objective. You help, while protecting your value. That balance is what makes the profession both complex and interesting. Push too quickly, and you lose trust. Move too little, and you lose momentum.

The best business development often emerges when you combine market signals with human signals. What does the strategy tell you? What does the budget tell you? But also: where are the frustrations, ambitions, doubts, or political sensitivities? Growth rarely happens on paper alone. Growth happens where market logic and human trust meet.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A business developer gains access to an interesting organisation, but there is no concrete need yet. The inexperienced instinct is to quickly make an offer anyway. The better approach is to build context: what is happening strategically, where are the growth opportunities, what pressures is management experiencing, and which previous initiatives have or have not been successful?

By developing a deeper understanding, the conversation changes. The business developer is no longer seen as a salesperson who has come to get something, but as someone who helps bring structure and clarity. Only when the urgency, timing, and value become clearer does a proposal become the logical next step. This strengthens the opportunity and creates a healthier relationship.

Business development therefore often means having the patience to become relevant first before trying to accelerate commercially.

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CHAPTER

# 13

# SCOUTING: WHERE ARE THE REAL GROWTH OPPORTUNITIES?

STATEMENT

> *Scouting is the art of seeing earlier what will later become visible to everyone.*

Those who observe better make better choices. And those who make better choices waste less energy.

That is the essence of scouting. Not taking action for the sake of action, but first understanding where the real opportunities lie.

Strong organisations do not simply move. They look first. They analyse. They scout. In elite sport, this is taken for granted.

You study the opponent, their form, their patterns, their strengths, and their weaknesses. In business, that discipline is at least as important, but often applied less consistently.

Scouting in business means having a clear view of your commercial reality. Where do you lose deals? Where does friction arise in the customer journey? Which KPIs really tell you something? Where is growth potential currently being underused? Which markets look attractive but are actually a distraction?

Many organisations collect data, but do not truly scout. They look backwards without giving meaning to what they see. Or they get lost in dashboards without gaining strategic insight. Scouting

requires more than numbers; it requires interpretation. It means connecting patterns to choices.

The quality of your analysis determines the quality of your tactics. If you misread what is happening, you choose the wrong move. That is why scouting is not something extra. It is a core strategic activity. Those who see better choose better. And those who choose better win more often.

I often see organisations struggle to distinguish between interesting information and decisive information. They know a great deal, but not always what truly matters. Real scouting forces focus. Which signals are relevant? Which patterns are persistent?

Which opportunities genuinely fit our strengths? Without that discipline, you start moving from restlessness instead of from insight.

### Scouting Questions

- Where do our numbers show us something we are not yet willing to fully confront?
- Which commercial patterns keep repeating themselves, positively or negatively?
- Which opportunities do we pursue because they look attractive, and which because they are strategically right?

Scouting requires the discipline not to fall in love with every opportunity. Many opportunities appear attractive because they are new, sound significant, or generate energy. But not every opportunity fits your strengths, timing, or positioning. Good scouting prevents enthusiasm from turning into fragmentation.

To do this, an organisation must learn to recognize patterns. Where do we win relatively easily? Where do we lose despite significant effort? Which customers become fans, and which customers consistently require too much energy? Which markets demand exactly what we are good at? Questions like these make strategy concrete.

The scout is therefore not the pessimist who holds back opportunities. The scout is the person who helps the organisation make better choices. By looking more sharply, you prevent teams from spreading their energy across too many playing fields at once. In business, focus is often not a lack of ambition, but proof that ambition is being taken seriously.

Good scouting also looks at losses. Lost deals, customers who go quiet, partnerships that fail to grow, and markets that deliver little despite significant effort: these are valuable signals. Many organisations prefer to analyse success rather than failure, but failure often reveals where the real opportunity for improvement lies.

Scouting is therefore a discipline of honesty. You must be willing to see that some opportunities are not the right fit, some propositions are not sharp enough, and some assumptions are simply wrong. That is not a weakness. It is exactly the maturity required to direct energy more effectively.

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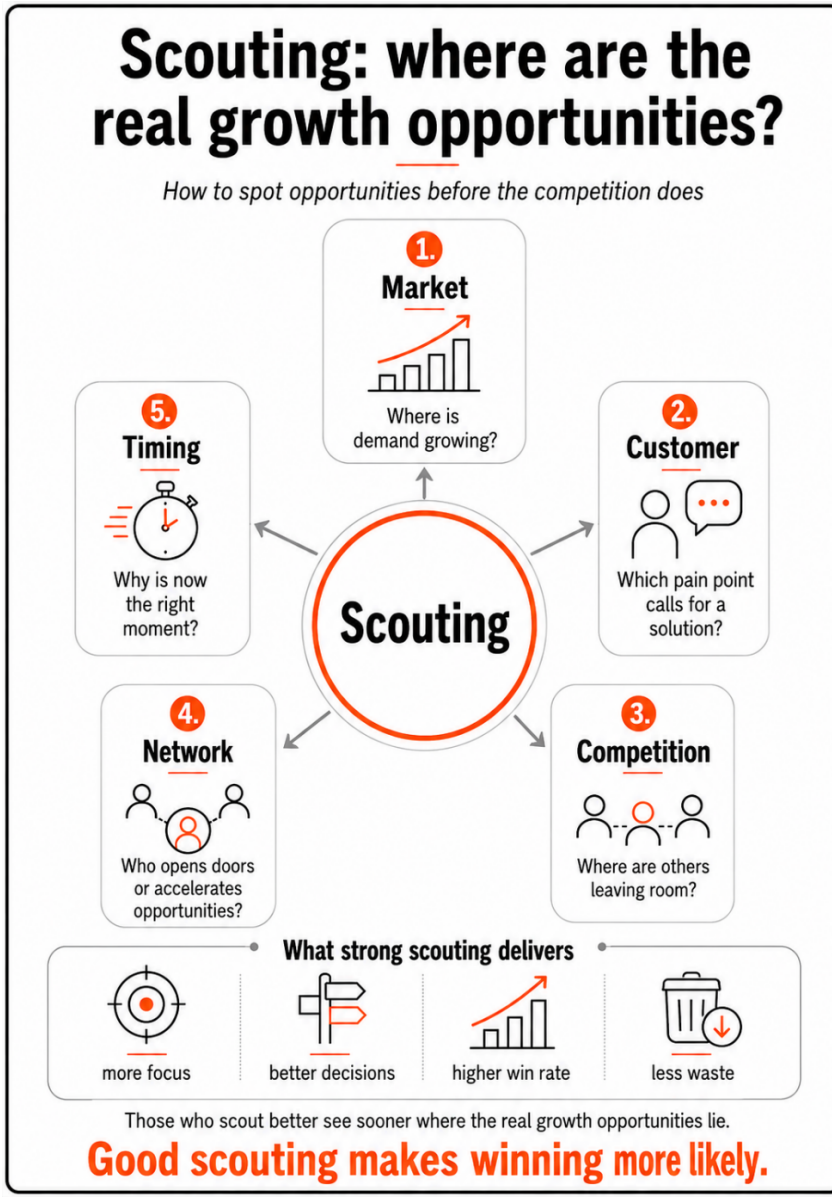
PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

An organisation identifies three potential growth markets and wants to explore all three at the same time. On paper, that sounds entrepreneurial. In practice, the team becomes fragmented. There is too little focus, too little evidence, and too little capacity to serve each market properly. Enthusiasm becomes a risk.

Scouting helps the organisation make sharper choices. Which market best fits our credibility? Where is the urgency greatest? Where do we already have access? Where can we build proof quickly? Which opportunity looks attractive but creates too much distraction? These questions make growth less opportunistic.

The best scout does not hold back ambition. The scout protects ambition from waste.

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Scouting: where are the real growth opportunities?
How to spot opportunities before the competition does
1. Market
Where is demand growing?
2. Customer
Which pain point calls for a solution?
3. Competition
Where are others leaving room?
4. Network
Who opens doors or accelerates opportunities?
5. Timing
Why is now the right moment?
Scouting
What strong scouting delivers
more focus
better decisions
higher win rate
less waste
Those who scout better see sooner where the real growth opportunities lie.
Good scouting makes winning more likely.

PART

# III

## THE 15 STRATEGIES OF BUSINESS ATHLETE

CHAPTER

# 14

# THE QUALIFICATION PHASE: SEE THE PLAYING FIELD BEFORE YOU PLAY

STATEMENT

*Those who sell too quickly often miss the real story; those who discover well increase the chances that every next step will hit the mark.*

Strong professionals are not always the first to have an answer. They are often the first to ask the right question.

That is the qualification phase. Not trying to sound smart too quickly, but first truly understanding.

The qualification phase is the art of truly understanding. Not only hearing what a customer says, but uncovering what lies behind it.

What interests are involved, how real is the urgency, which stakeholders have influence, and what is the context in which a decision will be made?

Many professionals present their solutions too quickly. They want to show what they can do, what value they offer, and why their proposal is strong. But without a thorough qualification phase, a solution can easily miss the real problem. You may sell something, but not necessarily what is truly needed.

A strong and effective qualification phase requires curiosity, patience, and sharpness. You need to listen without immediately trying to steer. You need to distinguish between symptoms and root causes. You need to know when to ask further questions and when to remain silent.

The qualification phase is not something to tick off quickly. It is the foundation beneath the rest of the commercial process. Those who truly understand the situation sell more effectively, advise more strongly, and build trust more quickly.

What I often see is that professionals become enthusiastic about their own solution too early. They sense opportunities, see possibilities, and want to move forward. That is understandable, but dangerous. Because the moment you move too quickly, the other person often stops truly sharing. That creates a false sense of clarity. A good qualification phase therefore also requires self-control.

### Qualification Phase Check

- What do I know for certain, and what am I mainly assuming?
- Have I uncovered the real problem, or only its first formulation?
- Do I understand the context, interests, and decision-making dynamics well enough?

A good qualification phase also requires courage, because sometimes you have to slow down while everyone already wants to move towards the solution. The customer wants a proposal, the seller wants to move forward and the organisation wants to see progress. But if the real problem is not yet clear, you are building on quicksand.

### What a Japanese Customer Taught Me About Listening

One of the most valuable commercial lessons I ever learned came early in my sales career.

I was working for an American technology company selling enterprise storage solutions for IBM systems. Part of our business model involved taking ownership of the customer's existing IBM disk drives and reselling them on the secondary market. That created an interesting commercial pressure: the value of those drives could fall every day. The longer a deal took to close, the more margin we potentially lost.

One opportunity involved the Dutch operation of a large Japanese multinational.

I had built an excellent relationship with my main contact. We understood the requirements, had developed a strong business case together and, in my mind, the sale was done.

There was only one thing missing: his Japanese manager's signature.

Days passed. From my Western commercial perspective, it was taking far too long. Every day's delay potentially reduced our margin—and my commission. I became impatient.

And impatience is a dangerous emotion in sales because it can persuade you that your urgency is also the customer's urgency.

I asked my contact to put some pressure on his manager to sign.

It seemed perfectly logical. It was a mistake.

The manager felt that he was being challenged by someone below him in the organisational hierarchy. Instead of accelerating the decision, the pressure had the opposite effect. He slowed it down.

Eventually, the contract was signed. The customer got what they wanted and my company made the sale. But by then, the resale value of the equipment had fallen significantly—and much of my margin and commission had disappeared with it. It was an expensive lesson.

The obvious conclusion was that I needed to understand hierarchy better. But the deeper lesson was about qualification.

I had qualified the technical requirement, I had qualified the business case, I had qualified the financial value.

But I had not qualified how the customer actually made decisions. I had filled that gap with my own assumptions.

From then on, every significant sales opportunity involved mapping the decision-making process: Who evaluates the solution? Who controls the budget? Who approves the proposal? Who signs the contract?

And, perhaps most importantly: who influences the decision without ever signing anything?

Over the years, I learned that successful selling is rarely about convincing one decision-maker. It is about understanding the complete decision-making ecosystem.

And there was an even broader lesson. Listening is not simply waiting until the customer has finished speaking. It is resisting the temptation to fill in the gaps yourself.

I had listened carefully to what my contact told me. What I had failed to do was remain curious about what I still didn't know.

The professional seller therefore listens not only to the answer, but also for what sits behind it.

What hasn't been said? What assumption am I making? What don't I understand yet? What could stop this decision from happening?

That requires curiosity. Patience. Silence.

And the confidence not to start selling too early.

A good qualification phase also requires courage, because sometimes you need to slow down while everyone else already wants to move toward a solution. The customer wants a proposal quickly, the salesperson wants to move forward, and the organisation wants to see progress in your sales pipeline. But if the real problem is not yet clear, you are building on quicksand.

A strong qualification phase goes beyond the first question. Why is this important now? What happens if nothing changes? Who is affected? Who benefits from the current situation? Which previous attempts have failed? What makes this problem different now compared with six months ago?

The better you discover, the stronger you can position later. You need to persuade less, because your proposal visibly connects to the customer's reality.

The qualification phase is therefore not a delay in selling, but an accelerator of relevance.

A powerful qualification phase can often be recognized by the quality of the summary. After the conversation, can you explain in the customer's own language what is happening, why it matters, who is involved, and what is at stake? If not, the qualification phase is probably not yet deep enough.

Silence is an underestimated tool in this process. Many professionals fill silence too quickly with explanations. But in that silence, the customer continues thinking, refines their answer, or reveals a more important layer. A strong qualification phase therefore requires not only better questions, but also the patience to let the answer truly emerge.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A customer says they need a new system. The salesperson could immediately start explaining what their solution can do. But a good qualification phase begins by slowing down: why now, what is going wrong in the current situation, who is experiencing the greatest pain, what is the impact of doing nothing, and what has already been tried?

These questions shift the conversation from product to problem. It may turn out that the system itself is not the real issue, but rather a lack of ownership, poor data, or unclear processes. That also changes the value of the proposal. The supplier is no longer selling functionality, but helping to solve a real problem.

Those who see the playing field more clearly avoid offering a solution to a question that has not yet been understood well enough.

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CHAPTER

# 15

# QUALIFICATION AND BUDGET: PLAY ONLY A MATCH THAT YOU CAN WIN

STATEMENT

> *Winning begins by clearly qualifying in advance who the decision-makers are at the customer—and, just as importantly, who the influencers are.*

Is there genuine urgency, and can you quantify it? Is there sufficient budget, time, and manpower to take on the project? And in the end, are you—because of who you are and what you bring—the one they choose to deliver it?

Not every opportunity deserves your energy.

That is a difficult lesson for many professionals, because activity feels safe. But focus wins more often than enthusiasm without selection.

Not every opportunity is a real opportunity. That is a tough but liberating truth. Many teams lose time, energy, and focus because they continue investing for too long in opportunities that were never truly viable. Qualification is not a bureaucratic step, but a form of professional respect for time and focus.

Good qualification means assessing whether there is a genuine need, whether there is urgency, whether you have access to the decision-making process, whether the problem is sufficiently

clear, and whether your solution is truly relevant. Without that clarity, activity can easily become an illusion of progress.

Budget is inseparably linked to this. Not because money determines everything, but because budget provides clarity about priority. Where there is no willingness to invest, there is often no real willingness to change either. That does not mean you should only work with wealthy customers. It means taking a serious look at whether the problem is important enough for the customer to allocate resources to solving it.

But budget is also about whether the customer has the time to implement the solutions you provide, whether they have the manpower available to do so, and perhaps most importantly, whether they genuinely want you to be the one to deliver.

Strong commercial professionals therefore also dare to say no. Not out of arrogance, but out of focus. They understand that winning often begins with selecting.

In practice, I see teams remain involved in hopeful opportunities for too long because no one wants to have the uncomfortable conversation: is this really an opportunity? As a result, the pipeline fills up with possibilities that exist on paper but have little real chance of success. That costs not only time, but also mental energy.

### Qualification Questions

- Is there genuine urgency, or merely polite interest?
- Do we have access to the real decision-making process?
- Is there a willingness to invest in solving this problem?
- Are there sufficient internal resources available to take on the project?
- Can the organisation allocate enough time to make the project successful?
- How strong is the customer's preference for us as the provider?

Qualification is also a form of self-protection for the commercial team. A sales pipeline full of weak opportunities may feel reassuring, but often creates uncertainty. People believe there is a great deal of potential, while the actual likelihood of success is low. As a result, forecasts become unreliable and focus becomes more difficult.

Good qualification asks uncomfortable questions early. Is there real pain? Is there an owner of the problem? Is there decision-making power? Is there budget, or a willingness to create budget? Is the urgency strong enough to overcome internal resistance? Without those answers, you are mainly selling to hope.

Letting go of weak opportunities creates room for stronger ones. That requires maturity. Not every friendly customer is a future customer. Not every interesting conversation is a deal. Not every request deserves the same amount of energy. Focus is a commercial weapon.

Budget should also be viewed more broadly than money alone.

A customer may have the financial resources, but lack the time, internal capacity, or political support. In that case, the opportunity is still weak. Professional qualification looks at resources, priority, decision-making power, and the ability to change at the same time.

The goodwill factor also belongs in qualification. Not as a vague feeling, but as a practical signal. Does the customer genuinely want to move forward with you? Do you get access? Is information being shared? Are agreed next steps followed through? If not, the opportunity may be less promising than the conversation suggested.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A prospect is friendly, enthusiastic, and asks for a proposal. The team feels hopeful. Yet there is no access to the decision-maker, no clear budget, and no strong urgency. If no one qualifies the opportunity properly, a great deal of time will be spent on a process driven mainly by polite interest.

Professional qualification makes this visible early. Who decides? Why is this important? What happens if nothing changes? By when does something need to change? What resources are available? If the answers remain vague, that is not a minor detail but valuable information. The team then has to choose: go deeper, requalify, or stop.

Saying no to a weak opportunity is sometimes the most commercially intelligent decision you can make.

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CHAPTER

# 16

# POWER MAP, PUSH & PULL AND VALUE-BASED SELLING

STATEMENT

> *The more complex the organisation, the more important it becomes not only to understand your value, but also the power dynamics in which that value has to land.*

In complex sales, it is not about one conversation. It is about the entire field of influence.

If you only focus on the person sitting across from you, you often see too little of the game that is actually being played.

Commercial success is rarely about convincing just one decision-maker. In complex organisations, multiple interests, levels, and forces are at play at the same time.

That is why a power map is so valuable. It makes visible who holds formal power, who has informal influence, and who can accelerate or block the process.

If you sell without a power map, you are often moving blindly. You may have good conversations, but still miss the real dynamics. You convince someone who cannot make the decision. Or you overlook a stakeholder who later applies the brakes.

Push and pull add a second dimension. Sometimes you need to create momentum, bring clarity, and provide direction. At other times, you need to create space, ask questions, and allow the

other person to move. The skill lies in knowing when to switch between the two.

Value-based selling completes the picture. Do not talk about features, but about impact. Do not explain what you do, but what it delivers. Customers do not buy a solution because you have put a lot of work into it. They buy when they feel that the value is greater than the investment.

In many commercial processes, too much emphasis is placed on content alone. Yet decision-making is rarely based on content alone. Interests, risks, relationships, timing, and internal politics all play a role. If you ignore that, you may assume that the best solution will automatically win. In practice, it is often the best understood and best positioned solution that wins.

### Influence Questions

- Do I have a clear view of both formal and informal power?
- Am I pushing too hard, or am I leaving too much untouched?
- Am I translating my proposition sufficiently into concrete business benefits?

A power map only becomes truly valuable when it is kept up to date. Stakeholders change their opinions, influence shifts, and internal priorities evolve. If you create a stakeholder analysis once and then assume the picture is complete, you often miss the dynamics that ultimately determine the decision.

Value-based selling also requires translating value into the customer's language. What may be an impressive feature to the supplier only becomes valuable to the customer when it improves something that matters to them: lower costs, reduced risk, higher revenue, faster decision-making, a better customer experience, or greater control.

Push and pull are not tricks, but forms of timing. Sometimes the customer needs direction and you need to help move the decision forward. At other times, the customer needs space to

build internal support. The professional recognizes that difference and adjusts without losing sight of the objective.

In complex decision-making, you also need to understand who feels the risk. Often the economic value is clear, but fear of failure, reputational damage, or internal resistance blocks progress. Value-based selling should not only increase perceived value, but also reduce perceived risk for the customer.

A good power map does not only show names and roles, but also interests, concerns, influence, and attitude. Who is the sponsor? Who is sceptical? Who benefits from change? Who risks losing control? Only when you understand those dynamics can you make value truly resonate.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A salesperson has an excellent relationship with the project manager and assumes the opportunity is progressing well. Later, it becomes clear that finance has doubts, IT sees risks, and a senior executive has different priorities. The salesperson had a good conversation, but not a complete picture of the power dynamics.

With a power map, it would have become clear earlier that different stakeholders assess value, risk, and influence differently. The salesperson could then have adapted the message: the business case for finance, implementation risks for IT, and strategic impact for the executive. Value-based selling means making the value concrete for each stakeholder.

In complex sales, you rarely win by convincing one person. You win by understanding and addressing the entire decision-making landscape more effectively.

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CHAPTER

# 17

# FRONTAL & FLANKING: TACTICS IN COMMERCIAL COMPETITION

STATEMENT

*Tactics are not a trick; they are the ability to adjust your route without losing sight of your goal.*

Not every door opens when you approach it head-on.

Sometimes you win by being direct. Sometimes you win by moving intelligently. Tactics are about knowing which route works when.

Not every game is won in the same way. Sometimes a direct approach is effective. Sometimes a flanking move works better. That is the essence of frontal and flanking: you choose not only what you want to achieve, but also the route you take to get there.

A frontal approach requires clarity, courage, and speed. You address the value, the urgency, and the difference directly. That can be powerful, especially when the customer is already aware of the problem.

A flanking approach is more subtle. You build access through another route. Through a different stakeholder. Through a smaller project. Through an issue that creates less resistance but still gives you access to the real core.

Strategically strong professionals choose their route consciously. They sense where resistance exists and where opportun-

ities open up. They understand that tactics are not manipulation, but intelligent movement.

In commercial processes, I often see people hold on to one preferred style. They are either very direct or very cautious. But tactically strong professionals are not rigid. They read the context and adapt their approach without compromising their integrity.

### Tactical Questions

- Where is the greatest resistance in this process?
- Which route gives us the best chance of gaining real access?
- Is directness powerful here, or is it simply too early?

A frontal approach works best when the problem is clear, the urgency is high, and access to decision-making is already in place. In that situation, directness can create trust. You show that you understand what is happening and that you are willing to address it openly.

A flanking move works better when resistance is still too strong or when the formal route does not create real movement. In that case, a smaller starting point, a different stakeholder, or a content-driven angle can help build trust and proof before the bigger step becomes logical.

The skill lies in not confusing tactics with taking detours out of fear. Flanking is not avoidance, but strategic access. Frontal is not bluntness, but clear direction. Both require maturity and a strong sense of context.

Tactics also require you not to fall in love with your first route. Sometimes the direct route turns out to be less effective than expected. Sometimes a subject-matter expert opens more doors than a formal decision-maker. Sometimes a small proof project creates more conviction than a major presentation. The professional keeps moving.

Integrity remains the boundary. Tactical movement should never mean manipulating people or distorting information. The best tactics are transparent enough to preserve trust and intelli-

gent enough to choose the right route. That is what makes tactics sustainable.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

An organisation wants to gain access to a major customer. The direct route through procurement produces little: the interaction is formal, distant, and mainly focused on price. A frontal approach has limited effect here. A smarter route is a flanking move through a substantive issue the customer is genuinely struggling with.

By solving a smaller problem, you create proof. By helping a subject-matter stakeholder, you build trust. By demonstrating value before the major decision is on the table, you strengthen your position. Later, the conversation with procurement can be conducted from a stronger position because internal support already exists.

Tactics are therefore the art of choosing the route that best fits the level of resistance, the timing, and the access available.

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CHAPTER

# 18

# IQ, EQ, FQ, SQ AND AQ: THE COMPLETE PLAYER

STATEMENT

*The complete player is not equally strong in every area, but knows exactly which strength will make the difference at which moment and acts accordingly. At the same time, IQ is increasingly being complemented—and in some areas replaced—by powerful AI applications.*

The modern professional rarely wins on the strength of one quality alone.

The days when expertise alone was enough are behind us. Anyone who wants to make an impact today must learn to combine different forms of intelligence.

Modern performance requires more than intelligence alone.

IQ (Intelligence Quotient) supports analysis. But without EQ (Emotional Quotient), connection is missing.

Without FQ (Physiological Quotient), focus is missing. Without SQ (Social Quotient), relational insight is missing.

Without AQ (Adaptability Quotient)—the ability to adapt—flexibility in a changing environment is missing.

The complete player is not the person with the highest cognitive capacity, but the person who integrates multiple forms of intelligence: someone who is strong on content and sharp in rela-

tionships, who can analyse and sense, who remains focused and adapts when reality demands it.

In business, you often see people who are highly developed in one area and underdeveloped in others. The smart analyst may lack relational awareness. The strong connector may lack sharpness. The fast decision-maker may lack nuance.

Development is therefore not always about more of the same, but about strengthening what is missing.

The professional who makes an impact builds a complete profile. Not to become average at everything, but to be broadly effective at decisive moments.

What fascinates me is that many professionals confuse their strongest quality with their complete profile. Because they are good in one area, they sometimes assume they are strong overall. But at decisive moments, blind spots become visible.

That is when it becomes clear that expertise without relationships is too limited, relationships without focus are too soft, or focus without flexibility becomes too rigid.

### Profile Questions

- Which form of intelligence do I naturally use most strongly?
- Which form of intelligence is underdeveloped in me?
- At which moments does my strongest quality actually limit my effectiveness?

The interaction between these forms of intelligence becomes particularly visible in customer conversations and leadership moments. You analyse the content, sense the tension, read the relationships, manage your energy, and adapt your approach.

When one of these elements is missing, the overall performance can become less effective.

That is why developing the complete player can never be limited to knowledge training alone. It requires reflection, feedback, practice, and sometimes confrontation with your own preferences. The rational professional may need to learn to feel more.

The socially strong professional may need to analyse more sharply. The energetic professional may need to recover more effectively. Growth lies in balance.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A consultant is extremely strong on content and quickly earns respect because of it. Yet he struggles in complex situations because he picks up relational signals too late. He hears the words, but misses the tension in the room. His IQ is high, but his EQ and SQ require further development.

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Another professional is socially very strong, but avoids rigorous analysis. She has a good sense of what people need, but does not make the business case concrete enough. That also limits impact.

The complete player does not have to be the best in every area, but must know which form of intelligence the situation requires at that moment.

Anyone who wants to perform at a high level develops not only their preferred strength, but also the missing link.

CHAPTER

# 19

# NETWORKING AND THE GOODWILL FACTOR: TRUST AS AN ACCELERATOR

STATEMENT

> *The goodwill factor is rarely a matter of chance; it is often the sum of preparation, reliability, and genuine attention.*

Trust accelerates what remains slow and difficult without it.

That applies in sport, in teams, and certainly in business. Access, openness, and decision-making move faster when trust is present.

Many business relationships begin rationally but deepen through trust. Networking and the goodwill factor are not secondary issues, but essential elements of commercial success.

Strong networking is not about broadcasting your message. It is about genuine interest, attention, reliability, and positive, recognizable energy. People feel the difference between someone who wants to use a connection and someone who genuinely wants to build a relationship.

The goodwill factor develops when people experience you as credible and pleasant to work with. When you say what you do and do what you say. When you do not think only about yourself. When you combine preparation with humanity.

Trust accelerates everything: access, openness, repeat business, collaboration, and decision-making. That means networking and the goodwill factor are not soft skills, but powerful accelerators of growth.

I have often seen two providers whose solutions were very similar in terms of content, yet the customer ultimately chose the one that inspired greater trust. Not simply because that provider was more likeable, but because they felt more consistent, clearer, and easier to work with. That is not a detail. That is commercial reality.

### Trust Questions

- How predictably reliable am I to others?
- Where do I build trust, and where might I unintentionally lose it?
- In my interactions, am I mainly focused on what I can get, or is it also clearly visible what I bring?

Networking becomes stronger when it does not begin with the question of what you can get out of it, but with the question of what value you can add. That could be an introduction, an insight, a sharp question, or simply being reliably present. People remember those who help them move forward without immediately expecting something in return.

The goodwill factor is not created by simply being nice. It is created through congruence. Do your actions match your words? Do you keep your commitments? Are you prepared? Do you show genuine interest? Do you remain professional when there is temporarily nothing to gain? These are the moments in which trust is built.

For business development, this is essential. A strong network is not a database of contacts, but an ecosystem of mutual trust. Those who manage that network carefully gain access sooner, receive more context, and are more likely to be given the benefit of the doubt.

Timing is important in a strong network. Not every contact needs to lead directly to an opportunity. Sometimes it is enough to remain relevant, share a useful development, or genuinely wish someone success. Such moments may seem small, but they build recognition and goodwill.

The goodwill factor is also strengthened by preparation. Entering a conversation with knowledge of the person, the organisation, and the context shows that the other person matters to you. That is not a trick, but a sign of respect. And in business, respect is often the first building block of trust.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

Two providers offer solutions that are comparable in terms of content. One only makes contact when there is something to sell. The other occasionally shares relevant insights, introduces people, contributes ideas without applying immediate pressure, and consistently keeps commitments. When an opportunity arises later, the difference in trust has already been established.

That is the goodwill factor in practice. Not as superficial charm, but as relationship capital built through consistent behaviour.

People are willing to give you the opportunity because you proved yourself reliable before anything was at stake.

Networking is therefore not a separate activity alongside business development. It is the gradual process of building relationships today that can create acceleration tomorrow.

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CHAPTER

# 20

# COACHING ON THE JOB AS A PERFORMANCE ACCELERATOR

STATEMENT

> *When development is separated from practice, growth slows down; when learning is brought into the workplace, performance accelerates.*

This is the second chapter on coaching on the job. Some interventions provide inspiration. Other interventions change behaviour.

Coaching on the job belongs to that second category: it has a direct impact on performance.

**Coaching on the job deserves significant attention in this book because it is not only a form of development, but also a strategy for acceleration. It makes performance tangible.**

Instead of talking about what could be improved, you work directly on the behaviour that influences results.

A good coach in the workplace observes, reflects behaviour back, asks questions, and corrects without taking over ownership. That is important. The objective is not to create dependency, but to strengthen independence.

## The Best Coach Makes Himself Unnecessary

I experienced exactly what that can look like with a Sales Manager I once coached. I'll call him Chris.

Chris came to me with a challenge. He was struggling to confidently map the decision-making structure within complex organisations—a costly weakness in B2B sales.

One of the strategies in my workbook provides a practical way to identify and map the key stakeholders involved in a buying decision.

Before our first coaching session, Chris asked whether I could send him some material in advance. It was a fair question. I believe strongly in preparation. But I didn't send him anything.

Instead, I smiled and said: “Hey buddy, roll up your sleeves. Let's get to work.”

I wasn't going to give Chris the answer. We were going to build it together.

I would coach him through the process, challenge his assumptions, ask questions and help him think. But ultimately, he had to map the organisation's decision-making structure himself.

There is a simple reason I believe in this approach.

When I was at school, I occasionally made cheat sheets before exams. The funny thing was that I rarely needed them. By writing them myself, I had already learned what was on them.

The act of creating the answer had become part of learning the answer.

The same principle applies in business.

If I simply give someone my stakeholder map, they may understand it. If I coach them to build their own, they learn how to think.

And that capability stays with them long after I have left.

That philosophy sits at the heart of my coaching-on-the-job approach. I don't want people simply to reproduce my answers. I want them to develop the confidence and capability to find their own.

Chris and I worked together for half a day each week over five months. As his confidence and skills grew, we expanded our work into other commercial and sales strategies.

Eventually, he no longer needed regular coaching. Today, we only occasionally spar when there is something worth discussing.

Interestingly, the result didn't go unnoticed. Four other members of his team subsequently asked me to coach them as well.

But for me, that wasn't the most important measure of success.

The real success was that Chris no longer needed me.

That is what good coaching should do. It should not create dependency. It should create confidence, capability and independence.

A good business coach should ultimately work towards becoming unnecessary.

### Why coaching on the job is more than guidance

Many organisations still treat coaching as a supportive luxury. That is an underestimation. Coaching on the job is not an optional extra alongside the daily activities of a business, but a direct performance lever.

Because coaching takes place in daily practice, insights are immediately translated into behaviour, behaviour into better execution, and better execution into measurable results.

Where traditional training often focuses primarily on transferring knowledge, coaching on the job accelerates the application of that knowledge in the real world. It is personalized, integrated into the work itself, and focused on immediate performance improvement.

Employees receive feedback at the moment it matters, enabling them to learn faster, make fewer mistakes, and reach the desired level of competence sooner.

That effect works at several levels simultaneously. At the individual level, it creates greater self-reliance, more self-confidence, and stronger motivation. Within teams, the quality of collaboration improves because communication becomes more concrete and expectations are expressed sooner.

At the organisational level, it creates a stronger learning culture, greater engagement, higher productivity, and ultimately better commercial results.

In that sense, coaching on the job is an accelerator of performance culture. It makes development visible in behaviour. It normalizes feedback. It increases ownership.

It also ensures that learning is not separated from results, but becomes an integral part of achieving them. That is why this method fits so well within organisations that do not simply want to talk more intelligently about performance, but genuinely want to become better at it.

When an elite-sport mindset is added to this, the impact becomes even greater.

**A coach with a sports background understands from personal experience how discipline, rhythm, focus, recovery, and performing under pressure are interconnected. As a result, coaching does not become softer, but sharper; not more theoretical, but more concrete; not more optional, but more purposeful.**

Performance accelerates when people learn more quickly from their own context. From their own mistakes. From their own conversations. From their own successes. Development then becomes not something alongside the work, but part of the work itself.

That is the great strength of this approach: learning becomes relevant, immediate, and sustainable.

In many organisations, development is still too disconnected from results. There is a development program and there is a performance objective, but the connection between the two remains weak. Coaching on the job makes that connection explicit. It demonstrates that development is not a luxury, but a performance lever.

**In practice, this means that organisations should not see coaching as a separate development program, but as part of the way they manage performance.**

If you want to improve performance, you need to make behaviour coachable.

If you want to strengthen culture, you need to create a consistent rhythm of feedback.

And if you want to increase commercial effectiveness, you need to bring learning much closer to execution than is usually the case in traditional development programs.

This also creates a much stronger business case for coaching on the job. The return is not only found in greater insight or motivation, but in concrete improvements in productivity, speed of development, error reduction, collaboration, and commercial effectiveness. In teams where coaching becomes a structural part of the rhythm, you often see proposals being prepared more sharply, customer conversations being conducted more effectively, follow-up becoming more consistent, and internal alignment requiring less energy.

**This also makes coaching on the job highly relevant for talent retention**. People remain connected to organisations for longer when they feel that their growth is taken seriously and that feedback makes them stronger rather than smaller.

Ambitious professionals want to feel that they are becoming better at their work. When that development path is missing, the likelihood increases that talent will leave or continue performing below its potential.

For commercial organisations, this is particularly relevant. The difference between activity and results is often small but decisive: better qualification, a stronger power map, a calmer negotiation, a better-timed follow-up.

These are exactly the kinds of behaviours that can be developed effectively through coaching on the job. Coaching therefore does not sit alongside sales; it becomes part of commercial execution itself.

### From Coaching Intervention to Organisational Impact

When coaching on the job is properly embedded, it creates a chain of effects.

- At the individual level, skills improve.

- At the team level, the quality of collaboration and feedback increases.
- At the organisational level, performance culture becomes more concrete and reliable.
- At the market level, this becomes visible through better customer interactions, higher conversion, and a stronger reputation.

In this way, coaching becomes more than a development tool. It becomes a lever that reaches all the way into commercial reality.

The organisations that achieve the greatest return from this approach do not treat coaching as a project with a beginning and an end, but as a permanent part of their daily operations.

In customer teams, in leadership, in commercial reviews, and in evaluations after important moments. That is exactly where a culture develops in which people do not wait for someone to formally train them, but continuously learn in the game itself.

### Acceleration Questions

- Which behaviours have the greatest impact on our performance?
- Where do people mainly need insight, and where do they need direct practice?
- How do we ensure that learning becomes a consistent part of the daily work rhythm?

**Coaching on the job works as a performance accelerator because it reduces the distance between insight and action.** Many professionals know perfectly well what they could improve, but in practice they fall back into old behaviour. The coach helps bridge the gap between knowing and doing at exactly that moment.

It is important not to make coaching too complex. Focusing on one concrete behavioural point at a time is often more effective than conducting a complete analysis of someone's personality.

The question is: which behaviour has the greatest impact on performance right now? And how can that behaviour be practiced today?

That is how momentum is created. People experience progress, teams see improvement, and leaders gain a clear language for discussing performance without becoming vague. Coaching then becomes not a separate program, but a rhythm of continuous improvement.

The acceleration in performance does not only come from the employee being coached, but also from the leader who learns how to coach. Leaders who observe better, ask better questions, and address behaviour more quickly raise the performance level of the entire team. Coaching then becomes scalable.

It is important, however, that coaching is safe enough to learn and sharp enough to grow. Safety alone can sometimes lead to comfort. Sharpness alone can sometimes lead to defensiveness. The combination of trust and clear standards is what makes coaching effective.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A team wants to improve the quality of its customer conversations. Instead of organizing another general sales training program, the leader decides to spend three weeks preparing, observing, and briefly reviewing real conversations. Each employee chooses one behavioural goal: asking better follow-up questions, summarizing more sharply, or closing more concretely.

After a few weeks, a visible difference emerges. Not because everyone has suddenly developed a different personality, but because the desired behaviour is practiced more frequently and adjusted immediately. The team develops a shared language for performance and sees more quickly what works.

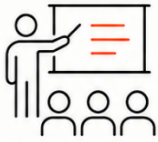
Coaching on the job accelerates improvement because learning takes place exactly where the result needs to be achieved.

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# Coaching on the job

*From knowledge to behavior in practice*

**1 Training**



provides language, models and insight

**2 Coaching on the job**



translates insight into concrete behavior

**3 Result**



strengthens performance, ownership and retention

## Why it sticks better



direct feedback



learning in real context



faster application



more self-confidence



**Training** = knowing



**Coaching** = doing



**Repetition** = embedding

Doing is the best way of thinking.

**Learning works best in the real game.**

CHAPTER

# 21

# COMPETITIVE, PORTFOLIO, PRICING, AND PARTNER STRATEGY

STATEMENT

*Strategic sharpness emerges when you have the discipline to make honest choices about where you want to win and how you can credibly get there.*

If you want to win, you need to understand not only yourself, but also the playing field in which you operate.

Strategy begins where honest assessment becomes more important than optimistic hope.

Commercial success requires not only the right behaviour, but also strategic sharpness. You need to understand how you compare with competitors, how you can increase value within existing customers, how you position your pricing, and which partners can strengthen your impact.

Competitive strategy begins with an honest assessment. Where are you genuinely stronger, and where are you not? Which competitor wins on price, which on brand, and which on specialization? Without that insight, overconfidence or confusion quickly arises.

Portfolio strategy requires you to look beyond the first deal. How can you deepen value within a customer? Which additional

needs exist? Where can you broaden your offering without becoming opportunistic?

Pricing strategy, finally, is not merely a financial exercise. Price communicates positioning. Those who discount too quickly often unintentionally signal weakness. Those who connect price clearly to value project confidence and maturity.

Over the years, I have developed a fairly uncompromising view of price negotiations.

Let me explain why.

Price negotiations are usually a sign you were too late.

Deep down, I believe that if you find yourself negotiating heavily about price at the end of a sales process, something has already gone wrong much earlier.

That may sound provocative, but over the years it has become one of my strongest commercial convictions.

### The €100,000 Conversation

Price negotiations are usually a sign you were too late.

If you find yourself negotiating price at the end of a sales process, something has already gone wrong much earlier.

That may sound provocative, but over the years it has become one of my strongest commercial convictions.

The real work in sales is not presenting your product or negotiating the final price. The real work happens much earlier—during qualification.

And by qualification, I don't mean deciding whether a prospect can afford your solution.

I mean understanding, in depth, what problem they are trying to solve.

What keeps them awake at night? What business risks are they facing?

Where are they losing money, time, market share or competitive advantage?

Only when you truly understand those questions—and your customer agrees that you've understood them!—does the sales conversation change. You're no longer trying to sell.

You're working together to build the right solution. At that point, you're no longer presenting a proposal. You're presenting **their** proposal.

One they helped shape, one they believe in, one that solves the problem they have already acknowledged.

Only then do you discuss the investment. And when that moment arrives, I often smile and say:

"There's just one thing left to discuss. The investment for this solution is €100,000." Notice I don't call it a cost. Because by now, the customer already understands what they receive in return.

Greater efficiency, lower operational risk, higher productivity, better business performance, stronger competitive advantage.

In that context, €100,000 is no longer perceived as an expense. It becomes an investment with a measurable return.

Of course, some customers will still ask for a discount. That is perfectly normal.

But here's something interesting I've noticed over the years.

A request for a discount is almost always one-sided. Customers rarely say: "If you reduce your price by 10%, I'll double my order." Or: "If you give me a discount, I'll sign a three-year agreement instead of a one-year contract."

Instead, the conversation usually starts and ends with one request: *"Can you lower your price?"*

Whenever that happens, I calmly ask another question:

*"I'm certainly prepared to discuss the commercial framework. May I ask what you're prepared to do in return?"*

That simple question changes the dynamic completely.

Negotiation should never be about one party giving something away. It should be about creating additional value for both sides.

There is another reason I am cautious about offering discounts too quickly.

The moment you immediately reduce your price, you unintentionally communicate something you never intended to say. You suggest that your original price wasn't really justified.

In the customer's mind, the conversation becomes: *"So apparently there was room all along."*

Worse still, you've created a precedent.

The next time that customer buys from you, they won't remember your original price. They'll remember the discounted one. And every future negotiation will start from there.

That makes it increasingly difficult to defend the true value of your solution.

Price is simply a number. Value is a perception.

Two people can walk into the same watch shop. One happily buys a perfectly good watch for €300. Another spends €3,000 on a different watch.

Neither of them is wrong. They simply value different things. The watch didn't change.

Only the perceived value did.

Exactly the same principle applies in business: customers rarely buy the cheapest solution.

They buy the solution they believe creates the greatest value.

The lesson is not that you should never give a discount. The lesson is that price should never become disconnected from value.

**And helping them recognize that value is the real skill of professional selling.**

Partner strategy completes the picture. You do not have to do everything alone. The right partners can increase reach, credibility, and commercial effectiveness. Here too, the principle is the same: choose deliberately. Not every partnership makes you stronger.

What I often see is that organisations would become strategically stronger if they made fewer assumptions and articulated more clearly what they actually believe. Less hoping that the market will automatically recognize their value, and more explicitly choosing how they want to position themselves. Strategy requires not only analysis, but also courage: the courage to choose, to define boundaries, and not to chase every opportunity.

### Strategic Questions

- Where are we genuinely distinctive, and where do we mainly believe that we are?
- Which customers or propositions deserve greater focus?
- Which pricing or partner choices truly strengthen our positioning?

Strategy only becomes powerful when choices reinforce one another. A sharp pricing strategy has little value if the portfolio is unclear. A strong partner strategy delivers little if the positioning remains weak. And competitive insight only becomes valuable when it is translated into deliberate market action.

Many organisations treat these topics separately. Sales looks at pricing, marketing at positioning, management at partnerships, and product at the portfolio. But for the customer, it all comes together. The market experiences one story, one level of clarity, and one degree of conviction.

That is why commercial strategy requires coherence. Where do we want to win? Where do we no longer want to waste energy? Which partners increase our credibility? Which price tells the right story about our value? Questions like these make strategy executable.

A strong portfolio strategy helps customers understand more quickly what they should and should not come to you for. That may seem restrictive, but it increases trust. Unclear portfolios create doubt. Sharp choices make it easier to become relevant to the right customer.

Price is also a form of communication. A low price can signal accessibility, but it can also create doubt about value. A high price can signal quality, but it requires proof and trust. The question is therefore not only what the market is willing to pay, but also what story your price supports.

PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A company offers many services, but customers find it difficult to understand what the company truly stands for. Sales adapts the story for each customer, marketing tries to communicate everything, and pricing varies significantly from one engagement to another. Internally, this creates flexibility, but externally, it creates confusion.

A sharper portfolio and pricing strategy forces choices. Which propositions are core? Which services are merely supporting? Where do we charge a premium because the value is demonstrably high? Which partners strengthen our credibility? By answering these questions, the market position becomes clearer.

Strategy is not only about choosing what you do. It is also about choosing what you will no longer allow to remain confusing.

PART

# IV

# FROM INSIGHT TO EXECUTION

CHAPTER

# 22

# WHY KNOWLEDGE DOES NOT GUARANTEE RESULTS

STATEMENT

*The value of knowledge is not determined by what you understand, but by what you are willing to consistently do with it.*

Knowledge is comfortable. Execution is confronting.

That is why so many organisations know a great deal and still achieve less than they could.

Knowledge is important, but knowledge is not enough. Many organisations have access to more information than ever before, yet still struggle with execution. That is because knowing and doing are fundamentally different things.

Knowing creates comfort. Doing involves risk. Knowing feels safe. Doing reveals where you still fall short.

As a result, many organisations remain stuck in analysis, planning, and discussion. It feels as though progress is being made, while behaviour does not actually change.

Results only emerge when knowledge is translated into choices, action, and repetition. When teams practice. When leaders correct. When feedback is acted upon. When insights are turned into rhythm.

The professional who makes an impact understands that learning only becomes valuable when behaviour changes. Execution is not the final step, but the test of every strategy.

I have seen many organisations where people were intelligent, committed, and ambitious, yet the translation into daily behaviour was insufficient. You then get impressive language about change without visible change in preparation, collaboration, decision-making, or customer interaction. The intention is good. The impact falls short.

### Execution Questions

- Where have we known enough for a long time, but still fail to act consistently enough?
- Which insights have we discussed too often without embedding them?
- What requires not greater understanding from us, but greater discipline?

Knowledge only produces results when it is translated into behaviour. That sounds logical, but in many organisations this is exactly where the leakage occurs. People know what customer focus means, but still prepare conversations insufficiently. They know feedback is important, but postpone it. They know focus is necessary, but still allow themselves to be pulled into busyness.

The gap between knowing and doing becomes smaller through rhythm, coaching, and consistent leadership. Not through more information. Many teams do not need a new model, but a better application of what they already know. The question is therefore not always: what do we need to learn? Sometimes the better question is: what do we finally need to start doing?

That makes execution even more decisive. Strategy without execution remains a promise. Knowledge without application remains potential. And potential without discipline rarely turns into impact.

The danger for knowledge-rich organisations is that they confuse analysis with progress. A good report feels like movement.

A sharp presentation feels like clarity. But only when behaviour changes do results emerge. Reality does not measure intention; it measures execution.

That is why every knowledge intervention should ultimately end with a behavioural question. What will we do differently tomorrow? Who will do what? How will we know whether it works? When will we evaluate it? Without questions like these, knowledge remains in people's heads and fails to become sufficiently embedded in the hands and feet of the organisation.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

After an inspiring workshop, everyone agrees that feedback is important. For the first few days there is energy, but after two weeks the old pattern has returned. Not because people failed to understand the message, but because no rhythm was created in which feedback naturally became part of the work.

The solution is simple, but not easy. Make feedback concrete, small, and recurring. After every important customer interaction, discuss one question: what did we do well, and what could we do more sharply next time? Let leaders set the example. Connect feedback to the work itself, not to formal performance reviews.

Knowledge becomes results when it is given a place in daily routines. Without those routines, even the best insight will fade.

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CHAPTER

# 23

# BUILD YOUR PERFORMANCE CULTURE IN 90 DAYS

STATEMENT

*Culture does not change when people understand the idea, but when the new behaviour begins to feel normal.*

Culture changes slowly, but forward momentum can be created quickly.

Not by trying to change everything at once, but by consistently taking a few decisive behaviours seriously.

A performance culture does not emerge in a single session, but in ninety days you can certainly create powerful momentum. The key is focus. Do not try to change everything at once, but choose a limited number of behaviours and rhythms that can have a significant impact.

**The first phase is diagnosis.** What is really happening now? Where are you losing sharpness? Where is follow-up falling behind? Where does friction arise? Which conversations are not taking place? Which standards are implicit but not explicit?

**The second phase is choice.** Determine which few behaviours will make the biggest difference. For example, better preparation, stronger follow-up, faster feedback, or greater ownership in meetings.

**The third phase is coaching.** Do not simply communicate what is important, but practice, observe, correct, and measure. Lead-

ers play a crucial role here. What they give attention to grows. What they allow to slide fades.

**The fourth phase is embedding**. Create rhythm, measurement points, and visible successes. Make behaviour discussable. Reward sharpness. Keep the standard alive.

The major misconception about cultural change is that people believe inspiration is enough. But culture rarely changes through inspiration alone. Culture changes when behaviour becomes more frequent, more visible, and more consistent. That requires rhythm. And leadership that continues to support it.

### 90-Day Questions

- Which three behaviours would make the biggest difference in our organisation?
- How do we make those behaviours visible every day?
- What rhythm of coaching and feedback supports the change?

Ninety days is long enough to make new patterns visible and short enough to maintain urgency. It forces an organisation not to remain stuck in big words, but to decide which behaviours need to change first.

A strong 90-day approach starts small and focused. Do not choose ten cultural themes at once. Choose a few concrete routines: better preparation for customer conversations, shorter evaluations after important moments, a weekly feedback rhythm, clear follow-up on commitments, and consistent leadership communication.

After thirty days, it should be visible whether the rhythm is alive. After sixty days, it should be clear where resistance exists. After ninety days, the new standard should not only have been discussed, but should also be felt in behaviour. That is when culture stops being a project and becomes practice.

The first thirty days are primarily intended to create awareness and rhythm. What is our current standard? Where is energy being lost? Which commitments are not being followed through

consistently? By making this concrete, an honest starting point emerges without the organisation having to solve everything immediately.

The second phase is about practicing and correcting. This is where it becomes visible who takes ownership and who falls back into old patterns. The third phase is about embedding: which rhythm do we maintain, what role does leadership play, and how do we ensure that the new standard does not remain dependent on enthusiasm?

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

An organisation chooses a 90-day program with one clear focus: better commercial preparation. In week one, the current way of working is assessed honestly. In week two, a standard format is created. From week three onward, every important customer conversation is briefly prepared and evaluated afterwards.

After thirty days, awareness increases. After sixty days, patterns become visible: some people prepare extremely well, while others fall back into old habits. After ninety days, the standard has been embedded in the team's rhythm. Not perfectly, but in a concrete and repeatable way. That is cultural change in practice.

The power of ninety days is that it is long enough to make a difference and short enough to avoid getting lost in abstraction.

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CHAPTER

# 24

# THE PROFESSIONAL IN ACTION

STATEMENT

*The professional who makes an impact does not wait for a better moment, but uses this moment to become better.*

Ultimately, everything becomes visible in behaviour.

Not in ambition, not in intention, not in presentation, but in what someone does when it matters.

The professional I describe in this book is not a theory. It is a practical mindset. You see it in how someone enters a customer conversation. In how a leader deals with tension. In how a team looks back on mistakes. In how a professional prepares for an important moment.

Being in action means taking responsibility for your own level. Not excusing yourself because of busyness, circumstances, or lack of clarity. Looking for influence instead of excuses.

It also means being willing to train what feels uncomfortable. Difficult conversations. Consistent follow-up. Honest reflection. Daring to remain silent. Asking deeper questions. Setting boundaries. Prioritizing. These are the skills that make the difference.

The professional in action understands that winning is a habit. Not a lucky break, but a series of behaviours that reinforce one another.

What appeals to me about this mindset is that it is available to everyone. You do not have to be a former elite athlete to work this

way, although elite athletes often have it deeply ingrained in them. You simply have to be willing to take your own level seriously. Not to keep letting yourself off the hook. To see discipline not as a limitation, but as an accelerator.

Perhaps that is the essence of everything I am trying to make clear in this book: performance is not an identity you possess, but a standard you maintain. Every single day.

### Action Questions

- In which area do I demand too little of myself?
- Which behaviour have I known for a long time needs to improve?
- Where can I choose a higher standard today?

The professional in action does not wait until everything is clear. They move forward with sufficient preparation and continue learning along the way. That is different from recklessness. It is the combination of thinking and doing: enough analysis to start wisely, enough action to create reality.

Many professionals remain in the safe phase of planning, refining, and considering for too long. But at some point, only action creates new information. A customer responds. A team moves. An objection becomes visible. An idea turns out to be stronger or weaker than expected. That is when the real learning begins.

**Doing is therefore not the opposite of thinking. Doing is thinking in motion.**

When you act, reality gives you feedback. And those who take that feedback seriously grow faster than those who wait for perfect certainty.

Action without reflection becomes busyness. Reflection without action becomes procrastination. The professional in action connects the two. They act, look back, learn, and move again. That makes growth practical and prevents development from remaining an abstract conversation.

One simple question can help: what is the smallest action I can take today that will provide evidence? Not the biggest promise, not the most impressive plan, but a concrete step that shows whether your direction is right. That is how progress is created without waiting for perfect circumstances.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A professional wants to become more visible to customers, but remains stuck in planning. He works on his proposition, refines his messaging, and thinks about the ideal approach. Meanwhile, very little is happening in the market. The breakthrough comes when he decides to have three real customer conversations every week and learn from them.

After the first conversations, it immediately becomes clear which words resonate, which assumptions are wrong, and which customer problems are more relevant than expected. The proposition improves through action, not through even more internal thinking. Doing creates feedback that paper never can.

The professional in action uses reality as a coach. They move, learn, and refine.

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CHAPTER

# 25

# ARE YOU READY TO PLAY AT THE HIGHEST LEVEL?

STATEMENT

> *Discipline begins with self-awareness: know what you can do and what you cannot do. Adapt your strategy accordingly and persevere in execution. Giving up is not an option.*

The real question is never whether you have more potential.

The real question is always: are you willing to carry the discipline that comes with that potential?

Ultimately, it comes down to one simple question: do you truly want to become better, or do you mainly want the feeling that you are working on it? That is a confronting question, but it is the right one. Because many organisations talk about an elite-sport mindset without embracing the discipline that comes with it.

Playing at the highest level requires sacrifice. It requires focus. It requires you to look honestly at where you are now and where you still fall short. It requires you not only to motivate people, but also to train them. Not only to talk about culture, but to build it. Not only to present strategy, but to execute it every day.

The world is not becoming less competitive. Customers are not becoming easier. Markets are not becoming calmer. That means organisations that want to win need more than ambition. They

need a performance culture, a rhythm of learning, leadership under pressure, and the ability to demonstrate commercial sharpness when it matters most. They need people who behave like professionals and take their own performance seriously.

The question is therefore not whether this is relevant. The question is whether you are willing to work with it.

Because if you want to win, you have to train.

### Final Questions

- Where am I still choosing comfort over growth?
- Where do I know that my team needs a higher standard?
- What would change if we truly started training for performance tomorrow?

Being ready for a higher level does not mean that you never doubt yourself. It means being willing to assess your current standard honestly. Where are you too noncommittal? Where are you hiding behind experience? Where are you better at talking about ambition than at training for it every day?

The highest level also requires you to let go of behaviour that may have been good enough in the past but has now become limiting. What brought you this far will not automatically take you further. Growth sometimes requires you to question your own formula for success.

That question applies to individuals, teams, and organisations. Do we truly want to become better, or do we mainly want confirmation that what we are already doing is good enough? The difference between the two often determines whether ambition remains a story or becomes a new reality.

The highest level also requires you to recognize your own excuses. No time, too busy, the customer was difficult, the organisation did not cooperate, the market was against us: sometimes these are genuine factors, but sometimes they are also protective stories. Growth begins when you honestly distinguish between circumstances and your own sphere of influence.

Being ready also means being willing to be coached. Not only when feedback sounds pleasant, but especially when it challenges you. Anyone who wants to play at a high level must learn not to take correction personally, but to use it professionally.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A team says it is ready for growth, but avoids making tough choices. Everyone wants more revenue, but no one wants to let go of weak opportunities. Everyone wants higher quality, but not everyone accepts feedback. Everyone wants a better culture, but uncomfortable conversations are postponed. In that situation, the ambition is greater than the standard.

Being ready for the highest level means facing that contradiction. Growth requires not only new goals, but different behaviour. It requires people to be held accountable for preparation, follow-up, collaboration, and discipline. Without that willingness, ambition remains just a nice piece of text.

The real question, therefore, is not whether you want to grow. The real question is whether you are willing to raise the standard that makes growth possible.

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CHAPTER

# 26

# GETTING STARTED: PRACTICAL TIPS AND FACTS – DOING IS THE BEST WAY OF THINKING

STATEMENT

*A quote by Mark Twain: "The secret of getting ahead is getting started," which can be loosely translated as: "The secret to making progress is to begin."*

## 1 The Business Athlete: Impact for the Employer

An overview of the organisational effects that coaching on the job and a stronger performance culture can deliver:

- higher productivity
- higher revenue
- higher employee satisfaction
- greater appreciation for leadership and management
- greater motivation and job satisfaction
- improved talent retention
- reduced absenteeism and employee dropout
- stronger reputation as an employer
- greater self-confidence and independence among professionals

- better collaboration and less frustration
- lower HR costs through reduced employee turnover
- greater commercial effectiveness in execution

### 2 The Business Athlete: Impact on the Employee

For the individual professional, the main benefits lie in direct application, faster learning, and sustainable behavioural change in practice:

- accelerated skill development
- proactive behaviour
- immediate performance improvement
- increased self-reliance
- reduced workplace stress
- improved decision-making
- higher efficiency and greater focus
- greater self-confidence in conversations and decision-making
- faster professional development
- practical knowledge acquisition rather than theory alone
- a steeper learning curve through direct feedback
- lasting embedding of new habits

### 3 Performance Culture Self-Scan

Use the questions below as a quick reality check for your team or organisation. Not to achieve a good score, but to make visible where training, rhythm, and sharpness are lacking.

1. Do we confuse busyness with performance?
2. Is preparation visibly the standard in our organisation?
3. Is feedback given directly, or mainly postponed?
4. Are responsibilities clear enough for people to hold one another accountable?

5 Do we evaluate mistakes as seriously as successes?

6 Do leaders respond consistently to behaviour that falls below the required standard?

7 Do people feel safer because of clarity, or more uncertain because expectations remain implicit?

8 Do we genuinely connect development and results?

9 Do customers experience more sharpness than noise in the way we work together?

10 What should we concretely train over the next 90 days in order to improve performance?

The highest level does not require more words, but more truth, more action, more coaching, and more courage.

### 4 The Four Playing Fields in Practice

Possible practical input.

**Quick Scan: Where Is Your Biggest Opportunity for Improvement?**

Answer the questions below with a score from 1 to 5.

#### The Field

- We consistently prepare important commercial conversations thoroughly

.....

- Our proposition is clear and aligned with the customer's real needs

.....

- We translate activity sufficiently into concrete results

.....

### The Captain

- Leaders provide calm, direction, and sharpness under pressure

.....

- Desired behaviour is visibly demonstrated by leaders

.....

- Decisions are made clearly and on time

.....

### The Fans

- Customers experience us as reliable, relevant, and valuable

.....

- We actively build trust and long-term relationships

.....

- We turn customers into fans rather than relying on one-off transactions

.....

### The Scout

- We analyse patterns before launching new actions

.....

- We know where we are missing commercial opportunities

.....

- Our strategic choices are focused and not opportunistic

.....

### Interpretation

3–7 points = performance is consistently leaking away here
8–11 points = functional, but with clear room for growth
12–15 points = strong playing field

## 5 The 90-Day Approach in Five Steps

### Step 1 — Diagnosis

Identify honestly where performance is currently getting stuck.

### Step 2 — Focus

Choose a maximum of three behaviours that will make the biggest difference.

### Step 3 — Training & Coaching

Make the desired behaviour concrete, observe it, and practice it in real working situations.

### Step 4 — Rhythm

Build in fixed moments for feedback, reflection, and adjustment.

### Step 5 — Embedding

Make improvements visible and keep the standard alive.

## 6 Questions for Leaders

1. Which behaviour in my team do I tolerate even though I actually want to change it?
2. Where do I provide too little rhythm around what truly matters?
3. Which higher standard currently requires the most from me in terms of leading by example?




## 7 Questions for Commercial Teams

1 Do we understand the customer's real needs deeply enough?

2 Where are we losing deals because of insufficient preparation?

3 Which habits make us commercially stronger, and which ones weaken us?

### 8 Personal Reflection

1 Where am I still choosing comfort over growth?

2 Which behaviour have I known for a long time needs to be sharpened?

3 What will I start training and coaching differently from tomorrow onward?

### 9 Coaching on the Job

**Quick Scan:** answer the questions below again with a score from 1 to 5.

### 1 Development in Practice

– We provide feedback close to the actual work, not only during formal evaluation moments

.....

– Managers and leaders observe behaviour sufficiently to provide targeted coaching

.....

– New insights are quickly applied in customer conversations, meetings, or decision-making

.....

### 2 Impact on Employee and Team

– Employees experience coaching as support to help them perform better, not as a form of control

.....

- Teams use feedback to collaborate more effectively and adjust more quickly

.....

- Learning and performance are visibly connected within our organisation

.....

- Employees experience coaching as support to help them perform better, not as a form of control

.....

- Teams use feedback to collaborate more effectively and adjust more quickly

.....

- Learning and performance are visibly connected within our organisation

.....

**Interpretation**

3–7 points = development is still too disconnected from daily practice

8–11 = a good foundation, but the rhythm is not yet strong enough

12–15 = coaching on the job is already a clear strength

### 10 When Should You Choose Training and When Should You Choose Coaching?

Use the following rules of thumb as a guide for making that decision.

Training is particularly appropriate when you want to introduce a shared language, method, or basic knowledge, and when a larger group needs to learn the same content at the same time.

**Coaching on the job is particularly relevant when behaviour needs to change visibly in practice, performance under pressure needs to improve, the main difference lies in application, timing, or execution, and you want to see faster results in collaboration, customer interaction, or leadership.**

### 11 Final Step: Act, Measure, and Adjust in Practice

**This is where everything comes together: mindset, leadership**, team performance, commercial effectiveness, and execution. Prepare to Win is not a separate method alongside the work. It is a way of taking the work itself more seriously, more sharply, and more humanely. Not by shouting louder that things need to improve, but by training more effectively what needs to improve.

Winning starts in preparation.

The question is not whether you are ready.

The question is whether you are willing to train what needs to improve.

# AFTERWORD

This book was written from the conviction that organisations are capable of far more than they often demonstrate.

Not because people are not smart enough. Not because there is no potential. But because, in many organisations, potential is not sufficiently translated into rhythm, behaviour, and execution.

The principles of elite sport show that consistent performance is never a matter of chance. It is built. Through discipline. Through sharpness. Through feedback. Through repetition. Through accountability.

That applies to athletes. And it applies just as much to leaders, teams, and organisations.

That is why Prepare to Win is not a collection of separate insights. It is an invitation. To look differently, to work with greater sharpness, to perform better and to make a greater impact.

**The game does not start tomorrow. The game has already begun.**

Finally, I hope that by publishing this book, I have fulfilled the promise I made to my sister and to myself.



*Harrie and Marella, 1965*

# NEXT STEPS FOR YOU TO WIN THE GAME

The practical value of this method emerges when leaders and teams do not treat it as a book that simply needs to be read, but as a standard that needs to be practiced.

Do not just read the chapters; translate them into behavior. Do not simply discuss the insights; turn them into agreements. Do not only ask what was inspiring; ask what will visibly be different from tomorrow onward. That is the point at which good ideas either gain momentum or disappear.

A simple way to begin is to work with three performance rhythms.

1. **preparation**: every important customer conversation, team meeting, or decision-making moment starts with a brief check on the objective, roles, context, and desired outcome.
2. **evaluation**: after every important moment, briefly discuss what worked, what could have been sharper, and what needs to be done differently next time.
3. **coaching**: every week, at least one concrete behavioral point receives focused attention in practice.

These rhythms do not need to be complicated. Their simplicity is precisely what makes them powerful. Five minutes of better preparation can change a conversation. Ten minutes of honest evaluation can reveal a pattern. One sharp coaching question can help someone avoid falling back into old behavior. The art is not to

make everything bigger, but to do the important things consistently.

For leaders, this means managing less on intentions and more on repeatable behavior. What standard do you want to see? Where is that standard practiced? When is it discussed? Who provides feedback? What happens when the standard is not met? When these questions return every week, a culture emerges in which performance no longer depends on motivation alone.

**For commercial teams, this means that sales is no longer seen as a series of separate conversations, but as a trainable process.** Qualification, power mapping, value creation, follow-up, and relationship building are not separate techniques. They are all parts of the same game. Teams that train these elements consistently increase not only their chances of generating revenue, but also their maturity and credibility as business partners.

**For individual professionals, growth starts close to home.** Not with a grand promise to yourself, but in the very next situation in which you can act differently. Ask one better question. Conduct one conversation more sharply. Ask for feedback one step earlier. Follow through on one commitment more consistently.

Repeat that often enough and you begin to build a new standard.

This is where everything comes together: mindset, leadership, team performance, commercial strength, and execution. Prepare to Win is not a separate method alongside the work. It is a way of making the work itself more serious, sharper, and more human. Not by shouting louder that things need to improve, but by training more effectively what needs to improve.

The power of this book lies not only in reading it, but in applying it.

Take one chapter, one question, or one principle and translate it into behavior in the coming week. What will you prepare differently? Which conversation will you conduct more sharply? Which commitment will you follow up more consistently?

Prepare to Win is ultimately not a theoretical method, but a daily choice. Every day, you choose whether to wait, postpone,

talk, and explain—or to train, adjust, act, and learn. That is where the real difference begins.

Make the method practical by starting small. Choose one team, one customer process, or one leadership rhythm. Measure not only the final result, but also the behavior along the way. Are conversations being prepared better? Is feedback being given faster? Are commitments being followed up more consistently?

When you start this way, credibility grows. People begin to see that a performance culture is not a large, abstract program, but a series of better choices made in daily practice. That is where the central motto of this book becomes tangible: **Doing is the best way of thinking.**

Getting started does not mean that everything has to change at once. In fact, sustainable change often begins with one visible rhythm. Choose one behavioral standard that matters, make it concrete, practice it every week, and discuss honestly what happens. That is how improvement becomes manageable.

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PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A leader who wants to start tomorrow does not need to launch a large program. They can begin with one simple rhythm: thirty minutes every Friday to reflect on performance behavior.

Which commitments did we keep? Which customer interaction could have been sharper? Which feedback did we postpone?

Which improvement will we take into next week?

Small questions. A simple rhythm. But repeated consistently, they begin to change the standard.

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